erosion of the tides

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by ohgentlegiant

Summary

Phainon prides himself on being able to make friends with anyone—that is, until Mydei joins the Chrysos Heirs. Phainon just wants Mydei to feel comfortable in Okhema, but the newcomer won't even speak to him—how is Phainon supposed to work with this? Like the waves eroding the earth, Phainon eventually wears away at Mydei's walls. What will he find when the waves crash down, and the sand recedes?

Notes

hello hello :3

i plan for this fic to be somewhat long-ish, but full disclosure i have never written a long fic so i have absolutely no clue how long this is gonna be. tags will be updated as the story progresses. thank you for joining me on this ride! with these words i hope to do phaidei justice T.T

i hope you enjoy!! comments/discussion/suggestions always welcomed :3

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Not for the first time since Mydeimos' arrival, Phainon was annoyed.

Mydei had officially joined the Chrysos Heirs the week before, on a day where the sun felt like it would bake anyone who lingered outside for too long upon the stone streets of Okhema. Phainon had been excited to meet a new face, for it had been more than four years since Hyacine had arrived from the Grove. He vibrated with a restless energy, which only grew stronger as he turned his eyes upon Mydei for the first time.

They found the newcomer in the courtyard, walking beside Aglaea as she gave him a tour of the city. Phainon had convinced Castorice to sneak out with him to catch a glimpse of the new addition to their ranks, and upon finding their target, they swiftly hid behind one of the pillars of the courtyard. Phainon peeked around the pillar, hoping to sneak in a peek without getting caught, but the sight before him caused him to lose his balance as he leaned a bit too far to the side.

The man shone under the hot sun, face turned away from Phainon as he followed Aglaea, his golden hair glinting under the light. He seemed to be practically carved from gold, from his skin to his armor—all except for the tips of his hair, which were dyed a deep crimson, a woven braid hanging along one side of his head. Well muscled and half-dressed, with red markings upon his back and arms, the man could have been mistaken for a mythical hero from times of old.

The scuff of Phainon's shoes upon the stones betrayed their presence. The newcomer and Aglaea turned to see Phainon and Castorice, neither of whom spoke immediately in hopes of avoiding Aglaea's knowing stare. The pair was most definitely supposed to be in the Garden of Life at this hour, assisting Hyacine with training the chimeras. Aglaea, uncharacteristically merciful, said nothing, instead motioning to the two of them while addressing the new recruit.

"Mydeimos, this is Castorice and Phainon, two of your fellow Chrysos Heirs," Aglaea said as she introduced them. "Castorice, Phainon, this is Mydeimos. I'm sure the two of you will make sure Mydeimos settles in well here in Okhema," she said with a pointed gaze. "Which includes setting a good example, such as not *skipping out on your duties*."

Phainon threw a shameless smile onto his face. "Yes, Lady Aglaea. We couldn't help it, we just wanted to catch a glimpse of our new friend!"

From beside him, Castorice let out a polite cough. "Apologies, Lady Aglaea. I only wanted to make sure Phainon did not manage to cause any trouble."

Phainon would have shot her a glare, but in the spirit of companionship he turned to Mydeimos instead. "Ah, Mydeimos, it is a pleasure to make your acquaintance. Please let me

know if there is anything I can assist you with to make your transition here easier." He beamed at Mydei eagerly.

However, Mydei only looked at him with a distant glance, and gave him a shallow nod. "Thank you."

A few beats of silence later, and Phainon realized Mydei was not going to say anything else.

…That's it?

Clearly, Mydei was a man of few words. Phainon couldn't help but feel slighted. He had always prided himself on being a friendly face, one people couldn't help but feel comfortable with right away. Mydei's silence felt like a blow to his pride.

He shook the feeling off. No matter. He would break the ice somehow.

Aglaea sent him and Castorice back to the Garden shortly after, but Phainon's excitement at Mydei's arrival still burned under his skin, lasting until dinner time, when Mydei finally joined the whole group for dinner.

Unfortunately, that excitement dimmed very quickly, when Phainon realized that Mydeimos was not going to be goaded into socializing that easily.

Mydeimos sat in the middle of the Chrysos Heirs, but did not join the conversation unless he was asked a question directly, and even then he would respond with brief, cursory answers, usually not even exceeding a few words.

Phainon returned home feeling more irritated than he had in a long time. He knew that he wasn't entitled to Mydei's friendship, but Mydei's unwillingness to make even simple conversation made Phainon feel like working alongside him would be fraught with tension—and as a team, tension was the last thing they needed. The task of making people feel comfortable usually fell to Phainon, but never before had he encountered a person as reticent as Mydei.

For the sake of the team, for the sake of Okhema—Phainon had to break Mydei's shell wide open.

Unfortunately, a week passed and Phainon was no closer to accomplishing his goal.

He had tried sitting next to Mydei at meals, but Mydei was no more forthcoming than he had been on his arrival. He never ignored Phainon, nor failed to answer his admittedly incessant questions, but his answers were never more than two or three words, and by the end of the third day, Phainon was no closer to understanding Mydei than before.

The first week passed by at a snail's pace, and Phainon felt like he had made no progress in integrating Mydei into the Chrysos Heirs. The itch of frustration nagged at him, but Phainon could do nothing about it. He said as much to Castorice one night over drinks in the market.

“I just can’t understand him, Cas. Like, what do I even do?” Phainon took another swig from his second bottle, his words already slurring.

Castorice sighed loudly. “Phainon, you can’t force the man to be friends with you.” Her face was slightly flushed, but Phainon knew that was practically as red as Castorice ever got. They usually went out for drinks every weekend, to drain off some of the stress from their busy schedules during the week. Phainon enjoyed the routine of it, even if it technically counted as an excess expense. He didn’t like spending his hard-earned money on frivolous things, but these weekly outings felt necessary to retain some of his sanity.

Phainon echoed her sigh. “I know, I know. But… People usually like me. Why doesn’t he like me?” he whined.

“Is that what this is about? Really, Phainon?” Castorice asked with a snort.

“No! Yes. Kinda?” Phainon’s thoughts jumbled in his head. “I mean, yes, I want to be his friend. But mostly I want us all to get along. It’s been so long since we’ve had someone new join the Flame Chase, Cas…” Phainon sighed again, already sounding like a broken record even to himself. “Everyone else gets along, so why can’t he?” he asked mournfully.

“Maybe he just prefers to be alone. And that’s okay, Phainon. Plus,” she added with a pointed look, “Mydei isn’t everyone. Haven’t you seen him fight yet?”

Phainon hadn’t. He shook his head.

Castorice widened her eyes, jabbing a finger at his forehead. “Go watch him train tomorrow. Then you’ll see.”

Phainon didn’t know what good that would do, but he had to admit he was curious. “Fine,” he grumbled. Mydei had been recruited to the Flame-Chase for a reason, and it certainly wasn’t due to his sparkling wit. Time for Phainon to see what he was really working with.

The next morning, Phainon dragged himself out of bed, splashed some water on his face and headed to the training arena after a quick breakfast. Castorice told him that Mydei usually trained before their morning duties began, before Entry Hour had fully given way to the light of the day.

Yawning, Phainon rubbed his face as he neared the training grounds. It was quiet, but he could just make out the sounds of the shifting of dirt, sandals scuffing the earth. He rounded the corner of the arena wall and stopped in his tracks.

Mydeimos was indeed there. That wasn’t what had surprised Phainon. It was just… Phainon hadn’t known what to expect, but he hadn’t imagined Mydei’s movements would be so...beautiful.

Mydei moved swiftly as he trained, each movement quick and precise, each position held with grace and no sign of discomfort. Phainon could see the strength behind each strike, the sword in his hand never wavering. He wasn’t sure how long he stood at the entrance, staring,

but he watched Mydei until the sun had risen fully and his neck began to sweat, stirring him out of his stupor.

Mydei finally stopped and returned his sword to the weapon rack. Phainon stood up a bit straighter as Mydei faced him, crossing his arms upon his chest.

He had surely seen Phainon watching him, but had not commented on his feelings on the matter. Instead he stood there, gaze meeting Phainon's. Phainon was startled to realize that Mydei was waiting for his evaluation.

"I was not aware you were so talented with a sword, Mydeimos," Phainon called out cheerfully.

Mydei dipped his head in a nod. "I usually prefer to fight with my hands, but I wanted to try something new," he responded.

Phainon stared. *Something new? Something new?* The words spun around and around in his head as he tried to process what he had just heard.

In an instant, all his years of learned politeness and etiquette went out the window, and Phainon could not have controlled the words that came out of his mouth next if he had tried.

"Will you fight me?"

Mydei stared at him.

Phainon's words burst out of him, unrestrained. "It's just—I've never seen someone fight so beautifully, and that's not even your weapon of choice? I want to see you fight for real."

"No," Mydei said.

Phainon could only gape at him. "But… Why not?"

"I do not want to fight you," Mydei said.

Phainon had no reply. He could only watch as Mydei left the arena, brushing past silently as he stood rooted in his place. While watching Mydei train, all of the frustrations of the past week had all disappeared, leaving only awe of Mydei's talent in its place. Now, those feelings swept back and hit Phainon like a raging force, giving him whiplash. Phainon was, once again, incredibly annoyed.

What was he supposed to do in the face of such stubbornness?

Chapter End Notes

tehe phainon doesn't know what hit him

thanks for reading! :)

edit: punctuation/grammar. you saw nothing. pls ignore any weirdness with author's notes, i'm still getting used to them hehe

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon had many good traits, but knowing when to give up was unfortunately not one of them. After seeing Mydei train, Phainon made it his mission to make Mydei give in. He would somehow make Mydei fight with him, whatever it took.

Whatever it took, he had thought. That was how he had landed in his current situation.

Phainon stood in front of Aglaea in the Hero's Bath, sopping wet and hair mussed, dripping onto the carefully polished tiles. Aglaea considered him for several long moments, then finally spoke.

"Are you quite in possession of all your faculties, Phainon?"

Phainon winced. Aglaea would not be pulling her punches today. He nodded.

"Then, are you perhaps ill? Injured?"

He shook his head.

Aglaea's stare pierced through him. "Then what could possibly be the cause of such *unruly* behavior?"

Phainon held his tongue. He had no good answer to why Aglaea had found him facedown in the public baths, the heat of the water so high that it had made him nearly drown the baths in his sweat. He had challenged Mydei to a test of endurance, to see who could last longest in the sweltering heat.

Mydei hadn't said anything, only closing his eyes as he sat down in the clear water. Phainon had lasted for nearly two quints, only getting up to follow Mydei as he made to leave, but Phainon had overestimated his stamina and passed out right there onto the gleaming tiles. It was a miracle of the Titans he hadn't cracked his head where he fell.

Phainon hung his head low in shame. He hadn't meant to make a fool of himself like that. And, as much as he disliked it, the incident had also brought shame upon the Chrysos Heirs —for one of Okhema's strongest protectors to keel over in the public baths, surely the members of the Flame-Chase must not be as indomitable as Aglaea proclaimed.

He could feel Aglaea's gaze lingering, but he still said nothing. He had gotten far too ahead of himself, only thinking of his own selfish needs, and had disgraced himself and his companions.

"Phainon," Aglaea said, voice gentler.

He looked back up at her. Aglaea no longer looked like he wanted to skewer him. Instead, her eyes were softer now as she gazed at him.

“I just—” he finally spoke, his voice dry. He started again. “I just…want Mydei to feel welcome here.”

Aglaea considered him for a moment, and then nodded. “I understand, Phainon.” She walked around her desk to sit down, and motioned for him to do the same.

“Mydeimos is…a special case. He has immense strength, and a soul of great value, but he has also known more pain than most,” Aglaea said.

“I do not think he wishes this to be widely known, but he is the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos.”

Phainon’s heart thudded dully in his chest. *Crown prince.*

The story of Castrum Kremnos was known to all in Okhema. Once a shining city of crimson and gold, it had been the very pinnacle of military might and heroic valor, now reduced to crumbling ruins. The dynasty had fallen after King Eurypon’s death by the hand of his son ten years ago, its people scattered to the wind as the city was invaded by the black tide.

Now, Castrum Kremnos was a name only spoken of in hushed whispers, the plight of its remaining descendants unknown and left to rot.

“He has wandered for a long time, and has experienced many sorrows since Kremnos’s fall. I do not believe, Phainon, that he will ever fully feel welcome here, or anywhere, for that matter.” Aglaea’s words were chosen with care, her face impassive save for a slight shadow in her eyes.

Phainon couldn’t reply. His throat felt tight. It all made sense now. Mydei’s fighting prowess, the elegance in the way he moved, like nothing Phainon had ever seen—relics of a time long past, belonging to a lineage that no longer existed.

Mydeimos had to be so lonely.

Not only after losing his kingdom, having to kill his mad father, but—Phainon suddenly recalled something he had heard when he was a boy, from a story about the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos.

“Is he…truly immortal?” Phainon asked slowly.

Aglaea nodded. “Yes, immortal of mind and body. Some call it a blessing, others a curse… But I suppose for the son of Strife, it is also an unshakeable duty.”

The duty of defending Amphoreus from the black tide, from the monsters that threatened the edges of the world, could only ever belong to the descendants of Strife.

Phainon felt sick.

“I know you wish to help him settle in, Phainon. But it may be that he will never find a place of his own again. That depends solely on Mydeimos himself.”

Aglaea’s words echoed through his head as he trudged home. He had thought that Mydei just needed a little time to adjust, and that no matter how quiet he seemed, he would eventually see Okhema as a safe place, and the Chrysos Heirs would make him feel welcomed, and they would all get along. Another gleaming cog in the well-oiled machine of Okhema’s strongest.

Phainon knew he could be a little short sighted on occasion, but never before had he felt so naive. Mydeimos was never going to be just another Chrysos Heir—his fighting prowess made that extremely clear. Mydeimos clearly had reason to not want to make friends, and even if Phainon wanted to understand him more, knock down the impenetrable wall of steel Mydei had placed between them, it was not Phainon’s decision.

It never had been.

Phainon’s head ached, and he threw himself atop his bed with a muffled *hmph* and closed his eyes. He dreamed of marble halls, rivers of crimson running into the sea, golden hair sinking like a stone, fading into black.

After hearing the truth of who Mydei really was, Phainon left the Kremnoan alone. He no longer had the urge to push Mydei’s boundaries, not after catching a glimpse of what truly lay behind his reticence. Mydei had lost his home, his family, everything.

Phainon knew what that was like. He did not want to intrude on Mydei’s life any longer.

The shift in Phainon’s behavior was evident. He did not follow Mydei around like a lost puppy anymore, nor beg him to fight with him at the arena after watching Mydei train. Phainon returned to spending his lunches with Castorice, which earned him several curious looks.

“Did something happen?”

Phainon looked up from his plate, mouth still half-full of food.

He hastily swallowed. “No.”

Castorice gave him a knowing look. “You’ve spent the last two weeks bothering Mydei, and now you’re back here? Phainon, I’m not stupid.”

Phainon shoveled the rest of the food in his mouth. “I mean it. Nothing happened,” he said as he stood up to return his plate.

Castorice didn’t say anything more as he walked away, but Phainon felt her violet gaze upon his shoulder blades until he left the canteen.

He didn’t know how to explain his recent behavior. Mydei’s secret wasn’t Phainon’s to tell, and as much as he wanted to share his recent turmoil, he felt bound by responsibility, and so

could not tell Castorice. Let everyone think he'd lost interest in annoying Mydei, and that he'd moved on. It's not like he could tell them anything different.

In the meantime, Phainon threw himself into his duties. Technically, the Chrysos Heirs were tasked with protecting Okhema from hostile threats, which sometimes meant going out on missions to fight the black tide, or capturing people who had committed crimes in the city to be punished. Most days, however, were extremely boring, with the duty of patrolling the city and the outlying areas split amongst the Chrysos Heirs, meaning Phainon really only patrolled once a week. Other than that, most of his time was spent in the Garden of Life helping Hyacine, or assisting to maintain the baths or the stables, or even mediating conflicts between citizens.

Most people assumed the Flame-Chase took most of the Chrysos Heirs' time and energy, but in periods such as these, when there was not so much as a whiff of a Coreflame within reach, the Heirs only had weekly meetings to discuss the Flame-Chase.

So Phainon was lucky enough to have lots of menial labor to keep his mind off of the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos.

It worked for a while, with Phainon avoiding any thought of the golden-haired man until the day he was finally assigned to patrol alongside Mydei.

Their shift started at the top of Parting Hour, when the sun began to turn everything its rays touched into soft gold. After dinner, Phainon stood outside of Marmoreal Palace to wait.

Mydei arrived not long after Phainon, armor glinting in the evening sun. It had been nearly three weeks since the baths, and Phainon hadn't spoken more than a few words to him in that time.

Mydei looked at him from the bottom of the steps, and said, "Let's go."

Phainon nodded, and pushed away from the wall he had been leaning against. "All right."

The patrol was quiet. Neither of them spoke. Phainon felt his skin begin to itch with the need to fill the silence, but he clamped the words down, the only sound at this hour being the rasp of their sandals on the stones.

It wasn't until night had fallen and they returned to the steps of Marmoreal Palace that Mydei broke the silence.

"You…" he began.

Phainon stopped, turning around to face Mydei where he stood a few steps below him. "Yes?" he asked quizzically.

Mydei stared at him impassively. "I did not take you for a quiet man."

Phainon blinked. When he didn't answer right away, Mydei continued. "Have I done something wrong?"

Phainon couldn't speak for a moment, but then shook his head. "No, no, I just… I've had some things on my mind."

Mydei was still looking at him, the sharp glint of his eyes barely visible in the darkness.

Phainon felt an urge to end the conversation quickly, so he scrambled to find an excuse. "I—um, I just… I. Uh. Family stuff. I'm gonna—"

"Lady Aglaea told you."

Phainon stopped mid-sentence, breath catching in his throat.

"What," was all he could manage.

Mydeimos crossed his arms in front of his chest, a familiar sight. "She told me what you discussed that day in the baths," he said, not sounding particularly angry or surprised.

Phainon didn't know how to respond. "Yeah. Uh, she did."

Mydei didn't say anything, so Phainon gathered his words and asked, cautiously. "You… aren't angry?"

"No," Mydei replied. "It is who I am. Just because I did not say it does not mean I am ashamed of it."

"I didn't—"

"But you pity me," Mydei's words cut in.

Phainon stared at him. Mydei thought Phainon *pitied* him? He realized that he hadn't disputed the accusation quickly enough only when Mydei's gaze shuttered and his mouth drew back into a hard line.

"I do not need your *pity*, Deliverer."

"I never said—"

"Enough," Mydei spat. "I am not deserving of your pity, so save it. I do not wish to gain the approval of this city by making Okhemans cry as they listen to my story of woe and anguish."

With not even so much as a glance in acknowledgement, Mydei spun on his heel and stalked away. Phainon's blood boiled under his skin, anger pulsing in his chest.

Mydei thought Phainon pitied him, and hadn't let Phainon speak more than two words in his defense. His body felt full of liquid fire, and Phainon couldn't bear to watch Mydei's form retreat in the distance, so Phainon left in the direction of his apartment, anger still simmering under his veins.

Phainon could deal with a lot of attacks against his character, but could not deal with the fact that Mydei thought he was so low as to *pity* him. Once he could think straight without wanting to yell, Phainon would have to make that clear, one way or another.

Chapter End Notes

meant for phainon to spend more time being a menace but the angst kinda pushed its way in there instead idk what to tell you

thanks for reading :3
- ogg

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon rarely ever was really, truly angry. This, however, was one of those times.

Mydei thought Phainon pitied him, which couldn't have been farther from the truth. How could Phainon pity him, when Phainon himself had been through similar pain?

Pity was born of condescension, was shallow and distant. What Phainon felt was something sharp and very, very close to home. If he had to choose one word to describe the mix of emotions he was feeling, Phainon thought it would probably be…empathy.

Pity was feeling sorry for someone, showing compassion for someone who had gone through *something*, but pity only required seeing the negative effects the *something* had brought. Empathy, however, meant that you felt the effects of the *something* too. Phainon had gone through many *somethings*, and no matter how different his situation was to Mydei's, the fact of the matter was that Phainon knew how Mydei felt.

And so it hurt Phainon, more than his pride would allow, to have Mydei believe Phainon pitied him.

It took Phainon a very long time to reach sleep that night, and he woke up feeling tense and off-kilter. He stumbled through his morning routine, and somehow managed to make it through his morning duties without tripping over his feet.

"Snowy!" a sweet voice chirped from behind him as he made his way to the Garden of Life in search of Mydei, after failing to find him elsewhere. Phainon turned and saw Tribbie, a basket of chimera treats in her arms as she bounded towards him.

"Lady Tribbie!" Phainon greeted her with a smile, his poor mood somewhat discarded at the sight of her.

"Snowy… Did you stay up too late again?" Tribbie frowned up at him, her red hair bouncing as she bobbed on her tiptoes, trying to examine his face more closely.

"Couldn't sleep," Phainon said sheepishly.

Tribbie somehow frowned harder. "Too much excitement late in the day will do that, you know! It's like you're still a little kid, Phainon," she chastised.

Phainon fought the urge to roll his eyes, which he knew would earn him a light smack on his arm. Changing the subject, he asked brightly, "Are you off to the Garden, then? I'll gladly take those to Miss Hyacine for you!"

"No, no, I can do it myself! Besides, I've got to talk to Cinny anyway," Tribbie said with a giggle, already setting off in the direction of the Garden.

When they arrived, the Garden was alight with activity. Apparently, Hyacine was preparing to host an event, the details eluding Phainon as he made his way through the throngs of workers carrying supplies to and fro.

Amidst the hubbub, Phainon saw Mydei not far from where he was walking with Tribbie. Phainon excused himself and walked up to him, not wanting to miss this opportunity.

“Mydeimos,” Phainon said.

Mydei turned, seeing him for the first time. “Deliverer,” Mydei responded in lieu of greeting, a thread of tension present in his golden eyes.

Deliverer. Besides Aglaea, Mydei was the only one who had ever called Phainon that. But now was not the time to ask about it.

“Can we talk?” Phainon asked, aware that this was the most courteous that he had ever been to Mydei. That was, of course, because before Phainon had never actually asked Mydei if he wanted to talk, only taking Mydei's silence as an excuse to press forward.

Mydei cast him a level look. After a moment Mydei nodded, apparently seeing something in Phainon’s gaze that made him acquiesce.

They went to one of the corridors encircling the Garden, searching for one that was unoccupied and found an alcove where they could speak freely.

For a moment, it was silent. Phainon knew he needed to be the one who spoke first but took a few extra moments to gather his courage.

”I do not pity you,” Phainon began quietly. Mydei said nothing, only listened as if he knew Phainon had more to say.

“Have you ever heard of Aedes Elysiae?”

Mydei shook his head.

“That was where I grew up.” Phainon shifted his gaze to watch the shadows flicker on the wall across from them. “It was surrounded by wheat fields, as far as the eye could see. The sea was right there, too. I used to sit on the dock for hours, staring at where the sunlight met the water. I think I might have permanently damaged my vision doing that,” Phainon winced, remembering.

“The air smelled sweet, of wheat and flowers, and—” Phainon’s head hurt a little, but he continued—“there were fairies, I think. Though I might have made that up. In any case, I had a happy childhood, running through the fields, playing hide and seek with the, um, fairies and my friend—Cyrene.” Phainon didn’t want to say her name but forced himself to anyway, ignoring the pang it brought.

Mydei hadn’t moved or said a word, so Phainon took it as permission and pressed on.

“But, the black tide eventually came. We were such a small village, with no way of knowing it was coming, with no neighbors to lend us their aid. It’s…um, it’s all ash now.” Phainon forced the words out. “I—anyway, I was the only one who ended up making it to Okhema. I was fourteen. Once they found out I bled golden blood, Aglaea brought me here.”

Phainon’s words kept falling out of his mouth, the shudder in his breath nearly betraying him. He was almost done.

”Ever since then, I have worked so, so hard to integrate myself into this city, with these people. I studied debate, learned etiquette and practiced the most I ever have, so that one day, I might not feel as out of place here. And yet,” Phainon looked back over at Mydei, “I still feel so *alone*.”

Mydei was still listening.

“So,” Phainon said. “I do not pity you, Mydeimos.”

Phainon hoped that was enough. He did not have the strength to express all of the emotions that swirled around in his heart at the moment, and hoped that Mydei would understand what he was trying to say. His heart pounded thickly, uncomfortable in the silence of the empty corridor.

There was nothing for a few moments more, until Mydei finally responded.

”Good,” Mydeimos said.

With that, the Kremnoan left. Phainon watched his retreating form until Mydei turned the corner, heading back in the direction of the Garden.

Phainon had no clue what Mydei was thinking, but nonetheless couldn’t help but feel the tiniest bit comforted.

After that, Mydei’s behavior towards Phainon decidedly changed. He would greet Phainon in passing, and respond to questions in longer sentences than before. They weren’t long by any means, or detailed, but it was such a marked shift from the past few months that Phainon couldn’t help but be taken aback.

Most notably, however, was that Mydei began sitting with Phainon during meals.

Phainon still hadn’t told Castorice about Mydei, or about their conversation outside the Garden, but Castorice seemed to know he had a good reason for not bringing it up, and had mercifully avoided the subject since that first day.

Presently, they were arguing about the recent increase of Aglaea’s parchment purchases. Phainon thought he might have finally convinced Castorice of his hypothesis when she suddenly stopped, but realized that she had only paused to acknowledge someone behind him.

“Good afternoon, Mydei,” she said politely.

Phainon's eyes widened and he went to turn around in his seat, but it ended up being in vain, as Mydei sat down beside Phainon with his cup and plate of food.

"Good afternoon, Castorice," Mydei said.

Phainon stared at him. Mydei only acknowledged him with a glance and then began to eat.

…*This was new*. The Chrysos Heirs ate lunch together every day, but Mydei had always eaten at his own table, never joining one of the various groups that were spread throughout the canteen.

Phainon didn't really know what to do with this new development, but supposed he couldn't complain. So he turned back to Castorice, continuing their conversation where they had left off.

"I'm telling you, Aglaea's been writing letters like crazy."

"That doesn't mean she's courting someone!"

"Why else would she be sending letters twice a week? And to the Grove, no less," Phainon said, shooting Castorice a knowing look over his sandwich.

"Oh, I don't know, Phainon, maybe she's just *doing her job*?"

Phainon threw his hands up in the air. "That's a flimsy excuse, and you know it."

"She could have found a pen pal."

"Who sends letters twice a week to a mere *pen pal*?" Mydei's voice came from beside Phainon.

The two of them looked over at Mydei, surprised. Mydei looked a bit as if he did not mean to say that out loud, but did not back down, golden eyes shimmering with the tiniest hint of mirth.

Phainon was the first to recover. "You see? Even Mydeimos agrees with me. I knew I wasn't imagining things."

Castorice only let out a small huff of defeat and changed the subject, clearly not wanting to linger on a losing battle now that she was outnumbered.

After that, Mydei's presence beside Phainon became a part of his new normal. Phainon figured that after their talk the other day, Mydei seemed to…accept him. Or at least, not resent his presence. It warmed Phainon's heart more than he wanted to admit that Phainon was the one Mydei had chosen to grace his presence with. Mydei did also start interacting more with Castorice as well, but that was honestly only because she and Phainon were mostly always together.

Mydei may not want to *make friends*, per se, but he had at least accepted Phainon's presence in his life. That was not an insignificant development in the least.

Chapter End Notes

honestly the beginning of this chapter was hard to write... i really wanted to show how deeply phainon resonated with mydei's plight, and how much he needed mydei to understand that his complicated emotions toward hearing his story was born from shared pain, and not pity. i hope that came across here ;;

this chapter marks the beginning of phaidei friendship arc i can't waitttt

thanks for reading :3
- ogg

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> there are some content warnings for this chapter, so please go to the end notes to read them!
>
> reminder to please check the tags again, i update them with every chapter so please take care of yourselves, and don't continue reading if these topics bring you distress!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After that, the ice between Mydei and Phainon finally broke, giving way to a quiet acquaintanceship. Phainon didn't delude himself into thinking they had magically become friends, but at least Mydei wasn't holding him at arm's length anymore. Phainon could be content with that.

At least, he thought he could.

Standing once again in the practice arena one morning a few days later, watching Mydei's flawless form move effortlessly as he trained, Phainon's mouth went dry.

As hard as he tried to control himself, he still really, really, *really* wanted to spar with Mydei.

After Mydei finished, he walked over to where Phainon was waiting so they could leave for midday patrol together.

"What," Mydei asked.

"Huh?" Phainon shook himself out of his daze.

"You're looking at me weirdly," Mydei said, golden eyes narrowed.

"I was just thinking how I really do want to fight you," said Phainon.

"No."

"Why not?"

Mydei glared at him. "Because I said no." He started walking, not bothering to wait for Phainon.

"Why, afraid you'll hurt me, Mydeimos?" Phainon jogged to catch up to him, slowing when he reached Mydei's side.

Mydei didn't respond.

”Or is it that I’m not worthy of fighting the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos?” Phainon teased, seeing no one around to eavesdrop.

Mydei glanced over at him but did not refute it.

Phainon’s jaw dropped. “Well, that is just *mean*, Mydeimos. I’ll have you know that I am the strongest fighter in Okhema! I can definitely handle whatever you throw at me.”

Mydei did not dignify that with a response.

Unfortunately, Mydei had the incredible luck of being stuck with Phainon for the time being, and Phainon did not relent in his pursuit of a spar for the entire patrol.

By the time they returned, Mydei looked like he wanted to shove Phainon into the nearest fountain, but did not so much as even try to lift a finger in his direction, much to Phainon’s chagrin.

Phainon knew he was pushing Mydei’s boundaries again, but the fact that Mydei continued to stick around him made Phainon think that Mydei didn’t really mind all that much. After all, Mydei could just go back to eating on his own if Phainon truly annoyed him, but every day at lunchtime, Mydei sat next to Phainon without fail.

So, Phainon reasoned, if Mydei needed someone to blame for Phainon’s pestering, he could really only blame himself.

The days flew by in a comfortable manner, with Phainon continuing to bother Mydei to no avail.

Eventually, the month of Freedom gave way to the month of Reaping, marking the start of preparations for the Festival of Cerces. The festival celebrated the beginning of the harvest season, which to most people meant a time of celebration and praise, but to Phainon meant that a sharp ache came to awareness in his chest, one that he could not shake away until the weather cooled and the leaves had all fallen from the trees.

Harvest time brought back too many painful memories, so Phainon naturally avoided anything to do with the Festival of Cerces. At least, he tried to. As part of the city leadership in Okhema, the Chrysos Heirs were tasked with the preparation and execution of the important festivals during the year, the harvest festival being one of the largest.

Every year, Phainon resigned himself to keep busy and his mind far away from useless thoughts. But every year he failed, the tightness in his chest giving way to sleepless nights and deep bags underneath his eyes. Phainon knew no matter what he did, this month would pass the same as it did every year.

Castorice knew better than to comment on it, as did most of the other Chrysos Heirs. Only Castorice knew the reason behind Phainon’s shift in mood, but even she did not know the details. Even so, she never pressed, only giving Phainon a quiet nod when he told her that he wouldn’t be available for drinks that week.

Instead, he went to the training arena after dinner. By this hour it would be empty, and Phainon could not be around another person for a moment longer. Nor could he go home and sleep, for he would only toss and turn until dawn. And even if he could sleep, Phainon knew nothing pleasant would appear in his dreams.

So, he trained. The arena had gone dark, the only sounds being the swish of Phainon's clothing as he moved through his forms and the shuffling of the dirt underneath his feet.

He didn't know how long he practiced for, only that when he stopped his muscles were burning and his heart pounding, the sound echoing through his head. He shut his eyes as he caught his breath, breathing in the cool night air, his greatsword landing in the dirt.

Phainon had only closed his eyes for a moment when his vision turned orange, lungs full of the scratchiness of smoke. His heartbeat sounded too loud for his chest, and Phainon felt a familiar sense of dread seize his bones.

Fuck. *Fuck*, not now.

Phainon's eyes burst open, and he made to leave, except—Mydei was standing in the entrance, watching him.

Seeing Phainon had noticed him, Mydei spoke.

"Do you always train in the dark?"

Phainon could not respond. He needed to leave.

He grabbed his greatsword from the dirt, but as he tried to walk past Mydei, he found his arm caught in the other's grasp.

Before Mydei could speak, Phainon wrenched his arm back. He couldn't do this right now. His breaths were already getting shorter. He couldn't be here.

Again Phainon tried to leave, but the shapeless emotions he had been fighting finally caught up with him, striking him all at once, causing him to stumble. The strength of the emotions almost forced him to his knees as he gasped for breath.

The pain in his chest made it hard to think, or breathe, or see. Phainon stopped existing for a moment, the ache in his chest almost strangling him. All he felt was that all-consuming fear, and he was back in Aedes Elysiae, watching everyone he knew die before him. He couldn't think, couldn't remember anything except for those scorched memories, and he burned. He was too slow, too weak, too far away to help.

Fire, smoke, screaming. Phainon couldn't breathe.

All of a sudden he was aware of a certain pressure on his body. Through the dizzying swirl of panic Phainon was fighting he slowly became aware of something encircling his arm, a molten pressure.

It grounded Phainon for a second, and for a moment he could hear again.

“Breathe, just take a breath. There you go. You’re okay. Just breathe, Deliverer.”

Through his daze, Phainon vaguely recognized Mydeimos’ voice. Right. Mydei was there. Phainon struggled to control his breathing, and after an indeterminable amount of time, the crushing weight on his chest lessened, and his vision cleared.

Phainon belatedly realized that he was now sitting down, leaned against one of the benches encircling the training arena. Mydei sat close beside him, concern visible in his sharp eyes.

“Mydeimos,” Phainon said. Or tried to. It ended up sounding more like a croak.

“Just keep breathing,” said Mydei.

Phainon put his head in his hands and kept breathing. He tried to feel anything but shame, to paste on the easygoing expression he usually bore so lightly, but could not muster the strength.

After a while, he could not stand it anymore. Phainon stood, brushing off the dirt where it clung to his white clothes.

Mydei stood with him, but did not say anything yet.

Phainon tried to smile, but it felt brittle. “Thanks,” he said, voice still sounding more fragile than he wanted it to.

“Do you…want to talk about it?” Mydei asked quietly.

Phainon thought for a moment. “No,” he answered, voice cracking. “I just want to stop thinking about it.”

Mydeimos considered him. “All right.”

Phainon took that as his cue to leave, but no sooner had he turned away did Mydei’s voice echo from behind.

“Then… Do you still want to fight me?”

Chapter End Notes

cw for this chapter: ptsd related flashback, panic attack
if this is not something you want to read, skip the rest of this chapter after phainon leaves for the training arena

a/n: if you noticed how there’s an actual day and night cycle in this fic that’s bc i totally forgot about the existence of the dawn device until this chapter… like no it was not on purpose i was just being silly goofy so pls ignore that discrepancy asfshjkl

thanks for reading! :3

- ogg

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

phainon finally gets his wish tehe

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Then… Do you still want to fight me?"

At those words, Phainon stopped. His head still hurt, the aching in his chest still pulsing under his skin, but Mydei's offer cut through Phainon's muddled thoughts like a knife.

"I thought you said no," said Phainon, confused.

Mydei was still looking straight at Phainon, hiding nothing.

"My pride will survive," he replied.

Something in Phainon's heart twisted. "Are you doing this because you feel sorry for me?"

"No," Mydei said. "I am doing this because I have stood where you stand now."

Phainon looked at Mydei for a few moments longer, assessing.

"All right," said Phainon finally.

At Phainon's words, Mydei went to the weapon rack and picked up the sword he often practiced with, adjusting his grip until it felt comfortable. Then he faced Phainon, waiting for his advance.

Phainon's greatsword was still on the ground where he had dropped it, so Phainon retrieved it and readied his stance. Then, he moved.

Mydei met his strike with a *clang*. Phainon had the advantage since his sword was larger and heavier, but the force behind Mydei's parry was stronger than Phainon had anticipated, causing Phainon's weight to list unexpectedly. Mydei took advantage of Phainon's shift in balance and counterattacked, blade moving swiftly to jab at Phainon's exposed stomach.

Phainon managed to dodge just in time, but it was a near thing. Chest heaving, Phainon studied Mydei.

Oh, this was going to be fun.

The two of them fought furiously, the sound of steel meeting steel echoing through the chilly darkness. With every strike, Phainon's thoughts traitorously threatened to rise up to choke

him again, but he fought them back, trying to focus on the rhythm of Mydei's movements, on meeting the slash of his blade.

"*Focus*," Mydei growled.

Phainon gritted his teeth and parried the incoming strike with an *oomph*, almost losing his balance, but his mind returned to the fight before him.

Phainon wasn't sure how long the fight lasted, but after a long period both of them just stood there, breathing heavily, their bodies mutually deciding to call a truce.

"You fought well," said Mydei, hair damp with sweat.

Phainon acknowledged that with a nod. "...Thank you."

A trickle of golden blood dripped from Phainon's brow, and he wiped it away with a grimace. Mydei's blade had broken his skin several times, all of them only shallow cuts, though there were too many for Phainon's comfort. Phainon had only managed to nick Mydei twice, but both times the cuts had closed up within seconds, leaving only slight shimmers of gold to indicate that Phainon's blade had ever met its target.

It both frustrated and fascinated Phainon, and he was once again reminded of the marvel that was Mydei's immortal body. Phainon was suddenly struck by a thought he'd never had before.

"Say, Mydeimos," he began. "Has no one else realized your body heals itself?"

Someone had to have noticed. Mydei's status as the immortal crown prince of Castrum Kremnos was not widely known, even to the Chrysos Heirs, but surely Mydei had been hurt in front of someone since arriving in Okhema. Even something as small as a papercut could have given him away.

Mydei walked past him to sit on one of the nearby stone benches, setting his sword down beside him. "No," he replied. "I am not around anyone long enough for them to notice."

Phainon didn't know what to say to that. He went to sit next to Mydei, arms propped behind him to keep his tired body upright.

"Sounds lonely," Phainon decided.

Mydei sighed, a novel sound. "Perhaps."

"If…I might be so rude as to ask, would you ever tell the others? About who you are, I mean," Phainon clarified, gesturing at Mydei's sitting form with one hand.

Mydei glanced at him. "Who I was, you mean. And what good would it do?" Mydei's gaze shifted upwards, toward the night sky littered with stars. "I have no claim to that heritage any longer. All I have now is a body that does not perish."

Phainon considered. “Surely there must be others from Castrum Kremnos who still wish to reunite with their own people. Is that not also a part of you?”

Mydei, somewhat surprisingly, did not bristle at the question, only answered honestly. “Maybe, but they believe the dynasty of Kremnos has not passed on. They would see me as living proof that the glory of Strife still lives. But they are wrong. That legacy died with my father, ten years ago.”

Mydeimos did not sound sad, only regretful as he gazed up at the stars. Phainon felt he was seeing a side of Mydei the other never got to show to anyone—the side that was just a man and not a prince.

After a while, Phainon realized his mouth no longer tasted like ash, and his heartbeat felt far steadier than before. He could still feel the threads of panic where they wrapped around his bones, but they felt thinner and easier to ignore, no longer strangling him from the inside.

Phainon didn’t expect Mydei’s presence to bring him such comfort, but had no intention of complaining. They sat together under the stars, not talking of anything in particular, until Phainon’s eyes finally began to droop and he left in the direction of his apartment.

He didn’t realize how much calmer he felt until the next morning, when Phainon realized he hadn’t dreamed of anything at all.

In exchange for skipping drinks, Phainon had agreed to meet Castorice for breakfast the next day. There was a stall in Marmoreal Market that sold the best honeycakes in Okhema, and the pair had to get there early if they wanted to grab some before they sold out. There seemed to always be a line wrapping around the stall, which only grew longer as the sun ascended into the sky.

As Phainon approached the stall, he saw Castorice had already ordered for both of them. She waved in greeting, but then peered at his face curiously. “Did you get in a fight?”

Phainon was startled for a moment until he realized the cuts on his face must still be visible. “Yeah,” he said, somewhat embarrassed. “I, um, sparred with Mydeimos last night.”

Castorice’s eyes nearly bugged out of her head. “You—with *Mydei*? Titans, Phainon, tell me everything. You’ve been begging him for *months*!”

Phainon told her over breakfast. She looked worried to hear that he’d had another episode, but said nothing until he finished narrating the events of last night. Phainon told her as much as he could without spilling Mydei’s secret, but Castorice didn’t push it, even though he could see she knew he wasn’t being entirely forthcoming.

“I’m a bit surprised, to be honest,” Castorice said, swallowing her last bit of hibiscus tea. “I thought he’d get tired of you bugging him to spar all the time.”

Phainon had the good sense to be offended. “I do not *bug* him,” he said, lying through his teeth. “If he didn’t like it, he would say so.”

Castorice shot him a doubtful look. “Are we talking about the same person?”

Phainon scoffed, shoving a bite of honeycake into his mouth. “Just because he doesn’t talk much doesn’t mean he won’t,” he mumbled around his food. “You know, I even think we’re becoming friends.”

Phainon did, actually. Just a few days before he would have thought it improbable, but after last night, Phainon suddenly didn’t feel friendship with Mydei was completely out of reach. Maybe just a little harder to get to, that’s all.

Now that he’d finally gotten to fight Mydei personally, Phainon couldn’t wait to do it again. Mydei moved like he was dancing, every step fluid and purposeful. Phainon itched to see it again, needed to learn how Mydei did it. He doubted his own way of fighting would ever become as beautiful as Mydei’s, but he’d be damned if he didn’t try.

He hoped Mydei didn’t think Phainon would let their spar be a one-time thing. Because now that the dam had broken, there was no stopping the waters from overtaking everything in their path.

Chapter End Notes

immovable object mydei meets unstoppable force phainon, except mydei is a lot less immovable than anyone thought (only for phainon tho o.O)

thanks for reading! :3
- ogg

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

> hellooo i am back after a little break! i am no longer unemployed (yeyeye) so i no longer have unlimited time to work on this fic (booooo)
>
> i hope you enjoy! :3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"You know," Phainon mused one day. "I've always wanted to learn Kremnoan."

Mydei was walking slightly ahead of Phainon, but did not turn his head to face him. "If you think I'm going to be the one to teach you, think again."

They were outside of Okhema's walls today, on a mission for Aglaea. There had been an increase in Titankin coming too close to the outlying villages, and the two of them were tasked with cutting down their numbers. Phainon had yet to spot one, but they'd only been outside the city gates for no more than a quint, so Phainon didn't let his guard down just yet.

"Why not? When else will I have the chance to learn Kremnoan nowadays?" Phainon looked over at Mydei, an innocent expression on his face.

"If you never even encounter the language, why would you want to learn it?" Mydei did turn to face Phainon this time, looking like he was already regretting asking.

Phainon grinned cheekily. "To learn more about you, of course! Plus, there's some books in Kremnoan in the library that I wanna read."

"If you can't even read the titles, why would you want to read them?" Mydei was scowling.

Phainon laughed. "Why, because I like the covers, dear Mydeimos!" He was mostly joking about asking Mydei to teach him, but Phainon had to admit that he was at least a little bit interested. He'd always been drawn to languages, thinking them to be somewhat of a secret code of sorts, and if he'd had any interest in continuing in academia he most likely would have chosen that as his research topic.

"*Haikas*," Phainon heard Mydei mutter under his breath.

The two had gotten closer these past months; it had been over a month and a half since that night when they'd sparred for the first time, and they had fallen into a comfortable routine of bickering, sparring and working together with relative ease. If Mydei was uncomfortable with the amount of time they spent together, he didn't show it—as much as Mydei acted like

Phainon's presence was an unbearable pain, he still ate with him and Castorice every day, and even waited for Phainon to finish eating so they could walk to evening briefings together.

Mydei's morning training sessions even expanded to include Phainon; instead of training separately they now spent their mornings sparring after a quick breakfast. Phainon had made noticeable improvements; he noticed his balance getting steadier after every session, and was even able to predict Mydei's movements to a degree after so long training alongside the other.

Now, midway through the Month of Weaving, Phainon felt at ease. The Month of Reaping had passed slowly, but eventually faded into the cooler, breezy days of Mnestia's domain, taking with it the sharpest memories plaguing Phainon's mind.

With Mydeimos by his side, soaking in the early autumn warmth, Phainon felt more himself than he had in a long time. The days passed by uneventfully, and as much as Phainon welcomed the quiet, he was itching for something exciting to sink his teeth into. Sparring with Mydei helped scratch that itch but only temporarily, making Phainon approach every spar with a vicious excitement.

As if the Titans had been listening to his thoughts and decided to grant his wish, Phainon finally spotted movement in the trees nearby. He readied his greatsword in an instant, Mydeimos moving at the exact same time, having heard the rustling of leaves and responding instinctively.

Giving chase, the two of them raced through the trees, whipping through bushes and orange-leaved branches alike. The Titankin was fast, but not fast enough; before long Phainon and Mydei had caught up to it and disposed of it with little more than a few slashes of their blades. They found several more Titankin nearby, tracking their trail until they found what looked like the biggest camp.

Clearing the camp took little time at all, and the two fought monster after monster until the clearing was completely silent, monster remains and thick splatters of black blood the only proof that the camp had once existed.

Phainon wiped the blood off of his sword as best he could, but knew he'd have to give it a thorough cleaning once they returned to Okhema. He looked over at Mydei, who was shaking the blood from his gauntlets, crimson markings gleaming in the sun.

Phainon couldn't help but be curious. He didn't quite know what the markings were—were they paint? Or were they possibly inked onto Mydei's skin? He didn't realize he was staring until Mydei cleared his throat, and Phainon's awareness returned to him in a jolt.

"Ah—my apologies, Mydeimos," Phainon managed. "I'm just a little curious… Are those tattoos? On your skin, I mean."

Mydei looked down at the crimson whorls adorning his skin, seemingly lost in thought. He didn't say anything at first, and Phainon was almost about to change the subject when Mydei finally spoke.

"These are a relic from my time in the Sea of Souls," he said.

The little Phainon knew about Mydei from before coming to Okhema was taken from stories, legends of the immortal prince of Castrum Kremnos. Apparently, Mydei had been thrown into the Sea of Souls by his own father in a fit of madness, before the mad king slaughtered Queen Gorgo in a fight to the death.

“Ah,” Phainon said weakly. “It’s not really that important—”

Mydei cut him off with a shake of his head. “It’s all right.”

“My father tossed me into the Sea of Souls when I was eight,” he continued. “I did not emerge for nine years, and when I rose from the waters these markings had already appeared.” Mydei’s voice grew distant, recalling.

“There was a prophecy made when I was born. That I would grow up to murder my father and lead the Kremnoan dynasty into ruin. Perhaps it was fate that saved my body from crumbling into dust at the first touch of those frigid waters, but others say that it was my strength of will that allowed me to endure. That, I do not know,” Mydei answered the unspoken question honestly. “Whichever it was, I arose with a body that no longer bleeds or dies, and these markings are only a reminder of the fate which binds me to a kingdom that no longer exists.”

“Do they hurt?”

Mydei looked at him strangely, and Phainon rushed to clarify. “I mean, the markings being a reminder of your past, the prophecy…” If it were Phainon, he wouldn’t want to look in the mirror and see remnants of a fate he was trying to forget.

Mydei seemed to get what Phainon was trying to say. “Yes. But every day they hurt a little less.”

Phainon understood. He, too, knew the pain of being the last of his line, of having no place to call home. He knew what a lonely burden it was to bear.

Mydei said no more, and Phainon gazed at him. A man destined for murder and strife, cursed to outlive everyone he knew, forced to wander the rest of his life. And yet, not cowed by fear or burden, just…undeniably alive. It brought a sharp ache to Phainon’s chest, and he rubbed at it absentmindedly.

Something about Mydeimos intrigued Phainon, the more he learned about him. As talented as Mydei was at fighting, he was not bloodthirsty, or violent. In both duties and battle he was meticulous and thorough, and he always fought with every ounce of his strength, but it was never out of a desire to cause pain or to vent his anger. When Phainon gazed at Mydei, all he could see was nobility, and strength—the strength of Mydei’s will, perhaps, but also of his character.

Phainon wasn’t sure he’d ever met someone as captivating as Mydei. The way he looked, the way he fought, the way he moved through a world that seemed to hold only cruelty for him.

“You’re staring, Deliverer,” said Mydei.

“I was just thinking… You fight so beautifully,” Phainon said.

“That again. If you say it again I’ll think you actually mean it.”

“I do mean it,” said Phainon.

Mydei stared at him, his golden eyes glinting with something unknown. After a moment, he turned away. “Let’s go back.”

Phainon got up, heart thumping strangely in his chest. The autumn light seemed to have cast a strange glow upon Phainon’s thoughts, but he pushed it out of his mind as they returned to the city together.

After returning to Okhema that day, Mydei began avoiding Phainon.

Phainon first noticed something was wrong the next day at lunch. They had sparred as usual that morning, and while Phainon noticed Mydei was quieter than usual he didn’t think anything to be out of the ordinary. Mydei speaking somewhat freely was still a relatively new occurrence, after all.

But when Mydei chose to sit in the far corner of the canteen instead of beside Phainon, where he had sat for the past few months, the message was clear.

Castorice saw where Phainon was staring across the room and followed his gaze. “What did you do?”

Phainon’s gaze snapped back to her. “Nothing!” he said indignantly. “Why would this be my fault?”

“Whose else would it be?” replied Castorice, looking back over at Mydei, her brow furrowed in concern.

She was most likely right, but Phainon didn’t like it. Nor did he know what to do about it. Phainon replayed his actions of the last few days. Had one of his jokes gone a little too far?

Nothing particularly offensive came to mind. Phainon kept wracking his brain all through lunch, but by the time he looked back over at Mydei, the other had already left.

The rest of the day passed the same. The two of them were not assigned duties together the rest of the day, but Phainon noticed how Mydei did not meet his gaze as they would pass in the corridors.

Phainon didn’t know what to do, and he returned home that evening feeling frustrated and confused. Just the day before, he’d felt as if Mydei had finally become a friend, only to turn around and treat Phainon more distantly than he had in months.

That night, Phainon’s dreams were restless. He woke the next morning earlier than usual, feeling ill at ease.

Phainon still went to the training arena that morning, seeing that Mydei was, predictably, already there. However, Mydei surprised him by looking him straight in the eye when he arrived, acknowledging him with a nod.

“Let’s begin.”

Stunned, Phainon could say nothing, so he readied his sword.

They sparred as if nothing had changed, the familiar sound of clashing swords breaking the silence of the quiet morning. After the dust settled, however, and Mydei left in the direction of the palace alone, Phainon saw Mydei’s face had reverted back to his silent, emotionless visage. The face that had been so animated during their fight was now an empty husk, and Phainon did not know how he could return it to what it once was.

Thick clouds of hurt and confusion flooded Phainon, clogging his senses. He couldn’t focus on anything all day, almost knocking poor Trianne into the baths as he carelessly turned a corner with a heavy crate in his arms during morning duties, failing to see her in his path as he trudged down the corridor, blinded by his heavy thoughts.

This went on for a whole week. Mydei stopped eating meals in the canteen altogether, and withdrew from the rest of the Chrysos Heirs entirely. The past few months, Mydei had on occasion been seen secretly helping with the dromases, and feeding them extra treats, but even that seemed to be no more.

Curiously, though, his spars with Phainon continued.

The two no longer spoke while they sparred, their challenging taunts and bickering nowhere to be found. Instead, their spars were silent but for the clash of their blades and the sound of their heavy breaths carrying through the air.

It was excruciating, but Phainon had no idea how to fix it.

It was only after a week of this that he decided their stalemate could not continue. Phainon felt like a coward to have avoided making a decision for so long, but a part of him had hoped that Mydei would come back by himself after a while, having realized how much he enjoyed having Phainon around.

Clearly, Mydei was not going to return on his own. Phainon made up his mind that he would speak to Mydei face-to-face, as he should have from the beginning.

Chapter End Notes

when there’s no consensus on mydei lore so you have to make it up yourself

also can you tell i have no idea how long a quint is LMAO

thanks for reading! :3
- ogg

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Phainon. A word?"

Phainon now stood, as he had many times before, in Aglaea's office in the Hero's Bath. Aglaea stood before him, drumming her fingers on her desk.

"You seem to be struggling with Mydeimos," Aglaea said.

Ah. Phainon should have known Aglaea would be informed of every last occurrence within the Chrysos Heirs, her golden threads keeping her up to date with any minute shift in dynamics.

"That is correct, Lady Aglaea."

Since making up his mind to confront Mydei the other day, Phainon hadn't had any luck in speaking with him whatsoever. Mydei was not going so far as to completely avoid Phainon, but whenever Phainon approached him Mydei would brush him off with a dismissive, "Not now, Deliverer" or "I'm a little busy".

The only time Mydei ever looked him in the eye nowadays was when they sparred, but that was not helpful in the least. No matter how much Phainon wanted things with Mydei to return back to normal, something about their spars felt sacred, and no matter how antithetical it seemed, Phainon could not bring himself to disrupt that.

Aglaea hummed musingly. "Well, I had hoped the two of you would be able to work things out sooner rather than later, but I suppose this'll have to do. There has been an increase in the smuggling of valuable artifacts of late; I suspect there's a larger organization behind it all. I'd like you and Mydeimos to investigate—find their hideout, and report back to me. Do you think you can do this?"

Phainon considered. "Yes," he answered truthfully. Both he and Mydei were diligent, and Mydei wasn't the type to let their recent strife interfere with a mission. And maybe Phainon could use this time with Mydei to finally iron things out.

"All right," Aglaea said approvingly. "Be prepared to depart at sunrise. I will inform Mydeimos."

By the same time the next day, Phainon severely regretted taking on the mission. Not only was the atmosphere between him and Mydei excruciatingly awkward, the mission itself was turning out to be extremely ill-fated.

The two of them were supposed to track the smugglers to their hideout, mark the location and report back to Aglaea. Unfortunately, the band of smugglers they were currently trailing had

apparently been hiding in a series of tunnels underneath the hills a half-day's journey from the city.

Phainon hated tunnels. He felt claustrophobic, and it was hard to breathe. Not just that, but he was pretty sure they were losing the trail, as he noticed what seemed to be the same fork in the tunnel for the second time.

"I think we've lost them," Mydei spoke aloud.

Phainon huffed out a breath in frustration. "Yeah. I'm pretty sure we're lost now, too."

Earlier, on the road, Mydei had refused to respond to Phainon if he tried to talk about anything unrelated to the mission, so Phainon had reluctantly turned away from all personal talk. It didn't make the situation any less frustrating, but at least the mission wasn't completely silent.

They hadn't had any time to come up with a new plan before Phainon heard scuffling behind them. He turned swiftly only to see one of the smugglers they had been tracking behind them. The smuggler, clearly surprised to have found others in the tunnels, stopped in his tracks when he saw Phainon and Mydei before bolting back the way he'd come.

Phainon cursed internally. *Great*. Now all their work would be undone, and they'd have to report back to Aglaea that they'd blown the mission by getting lost and getting snuck up on by the very people they were supposed to be sneaking up on.

Phainon would have suggested they call it off and head back to the city, but remembered that they were still in the unfortunate position of not knowing where they were.

Out of nowhere, the ground began to shake, the tunnel walls trembling. Phainon fought to keep his balance, but then the ground collapsed beneath his feet, and he knew no more.

The first thing he was aware of was a heavy weight pressing on his entire body. The second was that he couldn't breathe.

Phainon opened his eyes and could see nothing. Struggling, he attempted to shake off whatever was atop of him, but then immediately stopped, letting out a pained cry.

The weight wasn't on his entire body after all, only his chest, his left arm and his left leg; as Phainon opened his eyes again and his vision adjusted to the darkness, he realized his chest and the left half of his body were covered in rubble.

Suddenly, he remembered. He and Mydei had fallen, so they must be underneath the tunnels.

Mydeimos. Phainon tried sitting up with a wince, and scanned the area they had fallen into for Mydei. He found him, lying next to Phainon's feet, covered in just as much dirt and rubble as Phainon. Phainon couldn't fully move, could only prop himself up on his elbow as he called out, voice creaky.

"Mydeimos."

There was no answer.

Fuck. "*Mydeimos*!" he hissed.

Mydei groaned, finally rousing. Luckily, Mydei didn't seem to be hurt, and the rubble hadn't pinned any of his limbs to the ground, so he was able to sit up easily. He looked back for Phainon, apparently remembering the situation they were in, and their eyes met.

"Are you hurt?" Mydei called out tentatively, once he realized Phainon was conscious.

"N—yes," Phainon almost denied it, but what good would it do? "I can't move."

Mydei got up, moving to Phainon's side. "Are you?" Phainon asked, noticing how Mydei seemed a bit unsteady on his feet.

"Just bruised, I think," Mydei said, and helped shift off the rubble from Phainon's form. After a little bit Phainon could finally move, but sharp pain lanced through his left leg as he tried standing, causing him to hiss in pain.

"Here." Mydei helped him stand, supporting Phainon so he could sit against a nearby wall. Phainon winced as he leaned against the wall, his left arm throbbing.

"You're bleeding." Phainon looked down at his arm, only now seeing the golden blood staining the white fabric of his coat, enough to make him feel a bit queasy.

"Oh," Phainon said faintly. "That explains the pain."

Mydei looked at him with what could only be a glare, but quickly retrieved the bandages from Phainon's supplies, which luckily hadn't been damaged in the fall. Phainon gritted his teeth as Mydei stripped off his bloodied coat from his arm and cleaned the wound. It was not shallow, and would take a while to fully heal—Phainon must have gotten the gash from the rocks that fell on top of him, but he hadn't noticed the pain until just now.

After Phainon's arm was bandaged, Mydei went to look for a way out of their current predicament, and Phainon took the opportunity to assess their surroundings.

They had fallen into a cave, which was about ten paces wide and five paces long, the ceiling maybe six paces above them. It seemed like the smuggler scout had triggered a cave-in; Phainon couldn't see any source of light or a hole where they might have fallen from, and the pile of debris on the ground was substantial.

Mydei kept looking for an exit, but as time passed and Phainon's heart grew heavier, he couldn't help but feel helpless.

There was no way out. They were completely, thoroughly trapped.

Phainon balled his fist and hit the ground in frustration. *Why didn't anything seem to go right anymore?* These recent weeks had just been one headache after another, starting with the person sitting to Phainon's left.

Mydei had evidently given up searching for a way out; he was now sitting against the cave wall, eyes closed.

Phainon looked over at him, the frustration in his chest welling up, mixing with the anger that had been dormant these past few days. He tried so hard to keep it in, but ultimately failed.

“Why won’t you talk to me anymore?”

Mydei kept his eyes closed, but noticeably stiffened. He didn’t answer.

Phainon was truly angry now. “Why won’t you look at me? You can’t ignore me now. We’re stuck here until we find a way out.”

Mydei opened his eyes but didn’t meet Phainon’s gaze, his eyes instead resting on Phainon’s greatsword where it lay a short distance from their feet.

“You still won’t speak to me? What, you can’t be honest unless you have a sword in your hand?”

Phainon realized the truth of it as the words fell out of his mouth. Mydei, who had been shifting to presumably avoid this conversation, froze.

That was it, wasn’t it? Mydei had never turned Phainon away when they sparred. He still looked Phainon in the eye during those quiet mornings, face alive and full of determination, eyes blazing with anticipation of the fight.

Mydei had always been honest in the arena.

Phainon didn’t know what to say, the words he might have spoken caught in his throat. It was silent again while Phainon sat, dumbly.

“You…” Mydei’s voice broke the quiet. Phainon’s head snapped over to look at Mydei. He hadn’t honestly expected Mydei to respond to that accusation.

“You remind me of my friend,” Mydei finished his thought, head leaning back against the cave wall so he was looking upward.

Phainon didn’t say anything, only watched as Mydei spoke to him, *really* spoke to him, for the first time in a week.

“I used to have friends, once. After I returned from the Sea of Souls, I spent some time gathering troops, amassing an army to retake Kremnos. I still had people, then. My teacher, Krateros, and my friends…” Mydei’s voice tightened as he continued.

“They were my closest companions. I had known all of them since I was young, and they supported me unconditionally, no matter what path I took.

“Perdikkas, he died first. Then Leonnius, Ptolemy, and Peucesta. And finally…it was Hephaestion that fell. I killed my father, then left. I didn’t have a home anymore anyways. Krateros… I didn’t tell him I was leaving. It would’ve made me reconsider, so I just left.

“I walked the earth for ten years. I tried to escape my past—live somewhere quiet, make an honest living, but it never felt right. So I kept wandering. When I came to Okhema, I met you and everyone else, and I thought maybe I could get by. I thought I didn’t need anyone, was past needing anyone, and so I kept being alone.

“But then you kept showing up around me, and talking to me, and I found myself thinking that maybe it was okay to have someone stick around. I thought it was okay, but—” Mydei’s voice broke. He still stared resolutely at the ceiling of the cave, but his voice shook minutely.

“But the way you *looked* at me, back in the forest, I saw it clearly for the first time. It looked exactly like how they looked at me, how *he looked*—” Mydei’s voice cut off as he stopped abruptly, looking down at his knees. After a few moments, he took a shaky breath and continued.

“I just…can’t lose another friend.”

Phainon’s heart had been near bursting with anger in the beginning, which had now turned into a sharp, unbearable ache in his chest. Now, he understood.

“So…” Phainon began through the thickness in his throat. “You’re saying we’ve actually been friends for a while.”

Mydei turned his head, finally looking Phainon in the eye. He said nothing, but his eyes were rimmed in red.

Phainon sat up straight, moving his body to face Mydei directly, being careful not to jostle his injured leg. “Mydei, I’m not going anywhere,” he promised with the full weight of everything he was feeling.

”If you need me to swear it, I will. I swear. I am never going anywhere. You will never, ever have to walk through this world alone. I will become strong enough to never falter, so you’ll never have to worry about being alone again. I’ll be worthy enough to stand by your side,” Phainon insisted.

Mydei didn’t say anything for one long, heavy moment. And then finally he responded, in a softer and more honest tone than Phainon had ever heard him use, “You already are.”

Phainon couldn’t respond for almost as long. Only after he cleared the lump in his throat away and hastily wiped his hand across his eyes did he say, fiercely, “Then you can’t ever ignore me again.”

“I won’t.”

“Ever.”

“Never again.”

“Then we’re friends now, Mydei. You know that, right?”

“...Yeah, I know.”

Chapter End Notes

officially friends… after like 4 months… my brothers what r u doing

thanks for reading!
- ogg :3

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

After that, they sat in silence for a while. Phainon's face felt warm with the acknowledgment of what just occurred—Mydei didn't hate him. Mydei *did* like being around him. They were friends now, for real.

Phainon was lost in those happy thoughts for an embarrassing amount of time until Mydei spoke again.

"Now what?"

That brought Phainon's attention back into focus. They were still stuck in the cave, far beneath the tunnels they had been lost in earlier, with no visible way out.

"Now… We find the way out?"

Phainon tried getting back to his feet, but he'd forgotten how bad a shape his leg was in, the movement setting off an intense bloom of pain underneath his skin, bringing him back to a sitting position with a gasp.

He couldn't walk. At least, not at the moment.

Phainon let out a nervous laugh. "Ah, haha… Um, maybe I'll leave that to you, Mydei."

Mydei looked over at him, the barest hint of concern visible in the furrow of his brow, the usual gold of his eyes dulled in the darkness.

"Rest," he said, and returned to his search for an exit.

Phainon rested, but he wasn't happy about it. He hated sitting on the sidelines, wanted to help Mydei look for a way out. He didn't have much hope that they would find one, but he didn't want to think about that right now. Which was why helping Mydei would have been better and more efficient, if not for Phainon's stupid injured leg.

As he sat there, Phainon watched Mydei. Mydei searched every corner of the cave, checking the places he'd searched earlier with thorough diligence. Phainon could only watch, and it wasn't long before his eyes grew heavy with fatigue.

Phainon wasn't aware of falling asleep, or of dreaming, but he woke with a start when he felt a hand upon his uninjured shoulder. He blinked sleepily and raised his head.

Mydei was looking down at him. "I found a way out."

The so-called way out was yet another tunnel. Mydei had discovered it by pushing on the cave walls, trying to see if there were any hidden doors or escape routes—this tunnel had

been disguised behind a makeshift wall of loose rock. The smugglers, or whoever created these tunnels, must come down here regularly, perhaps to free any unlucky kinsmen who had been caught in one of their intentional cave-ins.

Phainon stared at the tunnel entrance from where he stood next to Mydei in front of it. He knew he couldn't complain, since they would probably be stuck down there to die otherwise, but he still hated it.

"I hate tunnels," he grumbled under his breath as Mydei helped him limp into the darkness.

The tunnel was darker than the ones they had been in above, and damp; Phainon could vaguely make out the sound of water dripping the farther they made it into the tunnel.

The going was slow; Phainon's leg allowed them to only move at about a snail's pace. Phainon kept glancing at Mydei to see if he was annoyed by their limited speed, but luckily Mydei didn't seem to mind. He stopped whenever Phainon's breath got too ragged, or his steps got too uneven, and they kept moving forward like this for a long time.

Phainon didn't know how long it had been since falling into the cave, and he hated not knowing. He just hated uncertainty in general—he wished there was some source of light they could see that could help reorient his body to his mind. The tunnel was leading them slightly upwards, so there was a chance it was leading them back to ground level, but there was no way to be sure. His head was pounding, and his vision was going a little fuzzy, but he just wanted out of these titansforsaken tunnels.

As he looked over at Mydei to check on his condition, Phainon's eyes caught on Mydei's hair. The red tips were slowly fading—Mydei would surely need to re-dye them soon. How often did he do that? The rest of his hair was the color of spun gold, glinting in the faint light —

Glinting in the light. *Light*.

Phainon's eyes snapped back ahead of them, and he could see a distant fork in the tunnel, the first they had encountered since entering. And on the left side of the fork, there was light.

His heart soared. They had made it.

The new tunnel indeed led outside; Phainon was half-worried it would lead to another cave, or perhaps if they were extremely unlucky, right to the smuggler's base, but it did not. Phainon had never been more happy to breathe fresh air.

The sun was high in the bright blue sky; they had been in the tunnels for at least a day, maybe two. They left the tunnels behind without a second thought, moving as far away from the hills as they could with Phainon's condition.

It was less than a quint later, when Phainon's leg threatened to give out from strain, that he and Mydei finally stopped to rest. They had made it to one of the forests circuiting the hills, and with the remainder of their supplies Mydei made a small camp.

Phainon had been moving forward purely on adrenaline, but now that they finally stopped he practically collapsed onto the bedroll Mydei had set out. His entire body ached, and his leg throbbed. He looked down and saw the bandages on his arm had been soaked through again, and every move of his head made it feel like it was rattling with crushed glass. Phainon let out a small noise of pain and frustration as he tried to get comfortable on the bedroll, very quickly finding it to be an impossible task.

Mydei looked over from where he was setting up his own bedroll, then came over to rest a hand on Phainon's forehead. Brow furrowed, Mydei removed it after a short moment.

"Fever," he said, and began redressing Phainon's wounds.

As Mydei rewrapped his bandages, Phainon felt a sudden absence of warmth, and he shivered. Mydei noticed and stared at him questioningly.

"Cold," Phainon managed out.

Mydei finished and laid him back down on his bedroll so he could rest, and Phainon's eyes shut almost immediately, pulling him under to the shores of sleep. Before his consciousness abandoned him, he heard the shuffling of leaves, and the last thing he felt before falling asleep was the weight of a warm chest enveloping his back.

Phainon's dreams were hazy, nondescript things. He knew he dreamed, but each fragment drifted away before his consciousness could anchor them to his memory. Phainon slept like this for an unknown amount of time, and when he finally woke, it was dark.

Phainon's head felt foggy, his tongue thick in his mouth, and he felt like he hadn't slept at all. His eyelids were incredibly heavy, but he had awoken to a terrible thirst, and he needed to drink something. Phainon tried to sit up, but found himself trapped. Through his haze, it took Phainon a few moments to realize that it was because someone's hand was across his chest, preventing Phainon from moving.

Phainon finally registered the weight of someone lying behind him, chest to back, and he turned on his side as best he could.

The hand wasn't just somebody's. It was Mydei's.

Mydeimos was asleep behind him, arm across Phainon's front as Mydei held him to his chest. He had evidently pulled his bedroll next to Phainon's to sleep next to him. It was immensely warm, and Phainon would have found it comfortable if not for the sudden realization that he was entirely too hot and completely drenched in his own sweat.

Water.

Suddenly reminded of the throbbing pain behind his eyes and the dryness of his throat, Phainon squirmed to release himself from Mydei's grip, fumbling in the darkness for his canteen. His fingers reached through the darkness, searching for the press of cool metal against his fingertips, but—

Mydei stirred behind him.

“Phainon?”

Phainon stilled. “I need water,” he whispered, his voice cracked through with dryness.

Mydei rose, the heat against Phainon’s back returning for a brief moment, and Phainon swallowed. His head pulsed with exertion, and he was too tired to do anything but watch as Mydei stood and retrieved his canteen from where it had been hiding. He held it to Phainon’s lips and allowed him to drink, water dribbling down Phainon’s chin after he gulped down several grateful swallows, only stopping when Mydei pulled the canteen away.

Mydei stoppered the canteen and put it down, and then his hand made its way onto Phainon’s forehead. It stayed there for a moment until Mydei finally retrieved it, his eyes somewhat displeased.

“Your fever… It’s too high,” Mydei muttered, almost to himself.

Phainon watched through droopy eyes as Mydei went to rummage through their supplies, returning with more bandages and another one of their canteens. Phainon blinked heavily as he fought to stay awake, opening his eyes to look up at Mydei when he felt the coolness of a compress on his forehead.

Mydei was wiping the sweat from his brow, sharp eyes unreadable in the darkness. He noticed Phainon watching him, but only said, “Sleep.”

Phainon closed his eyes, and slept.

The next time Phainon woke, he did not see the yellow-red canopy of trees he had fallen asleep under, instead he woke up to see a ceiling. He was in a bedroom—not his, and neither was he in Okhema; as Phainon turned his head he saw a window on the adjacent wall, outside an unfamiliar landscape of trees and rolling hills.

His body didn’t feel as heavy, and his head felt lighter. Phainon was surprised that sitting up wasn’t difficult, and he lifted the covers to see his left arm had been wrapped in clean bandages once again.

The room was quiet, and Phainon was considering what to do next when the door to the bedroom suddenly opened.

It was Mydeimos. He looked cleaner, the dirt and grime from the last few days nowhere to be seen.

“Your fever got worse,” Mydei said, gesturing to the bedroom. “I found a house nearby and asked for a spare room and some medicine.”

“Ah,” Phainon said, the weakness in his voice surprising him. He cleared his throat and tried again, but his voice still came out raspy.

Mydei walked over to the side of the bed and handed Phainon a glass of water that had been set upon it. Phainon accepted it gratefully and drank, the coolness of the water soothing his throat.

Once he had drunk his fill, and Mydei returned the glass to the bedside table, Phainon felt a slow rush of embarrassment, brought on by the memories of the past few days.

“Um,” Phainon began. “I’m sorry.”

Mydei shook his head once. “No, I… I should have caught your fever earlier.”

Phainon shook his head, echoing Mydei. “No—you got us out of there, and I ended up not being able to help at all…”

Mydei lowered his head, as if deciding whether or not to shake the acknowledgement off, but ultimately returned his gaze to Phainon’s. Changing the subject, he asked, “How are you feeling?”

“Better,” Phainon answered honestly. “Not like death, anyway.”

Mydei looked him over once, assessing, then nodded, seeming accepting Phainon’s self-evaluation. “All right,” he said. “You should get more rest, and then we can return tomorrow.”

Phainon agreed. He felt infinitely better than he had in the forest, but he knew he shouldn’t push his body right away, even though he was itching to return to Okhema and his normal routine.

Before Mydei could leave, Phainon found the courage to speak up.

“Mydei?”

Mydei turned to look at him, hand on the doorknob.

“Thank you.”

Mydei gazed at him for a moment, then nodded, closing the door behind him as he left.

Phainon was sentenced to bed rest for the rest of the day, with plans to leave the next morning. Mydei slept in a cot in the corner of their room, refusing Phainon’s insistence that he should take the cot instead, as he didn’t feel sick anymore, and they left the next day after breakfast, making sure to thank the family whose spare room they had commandeered profusely.

Their hosts also insisted on sending them with a horse, given Phainon’s state, but relented after Phainon insisted he could walk without aid. His body was in much better shape than it had been days before, the pain in his arm and leg only mild, and his fever long gone.

The return journey took twice as long, since Phainon couldn’t maintain his usual speed with his weakened body, but the atmosphere between the two of them felt completely different

than when they had set out only half a week before—instead of pained silence, conversation between Mydei and Phainon returned to a semblance of what it once was, and the conversation now flowed easily, a reminder of their newly forged friendship.

Mydei even smiled occasionally at some of Phainon's stories, which made the idea that had half-formed in the back of Phainon's head that he had imagined their conversation in the tunnels fully evaporate. The image of Mydei's little half-smile made Phainon's chest swell up with something unnameable, and Phainon kept telling more and more absurd stories in the hopes of seeing it again.

So it happened that when they arrived back in Okhema, they were both in good spirits, and Phainon was looking forward to the heaping plate of cheese pies he would devour when they returned.

The pair needed to report to Aglaea before they could be released to their own devices, so they headed to Aglaea's office. As they rode the lift up to the Hero's Bath, Phainon snuck a glance over at Mydei.

So much had changed during this mission, and Phainon couldn't help but feel excited for what was to come. With Mydei by his side, he felt a sense of camaraderie and comfort, one he hadn't felt since he was a child, running through the fields with Cyrene.

Everything was looking up.

As the lift reached the uppermost level of the baths, Phainon was startled to see Aglaea was already waiting for them. Except—no, she was talking with someone, a man Phainon didn't recognize.

Mydei froze, and Phainon looked over to ask what was wrong, but the words died in his throat as he saw the stricken expression on Mydei's face.

Aglaea and the stranger had noticed the arrival of the lift, and turned to face them both. The stranger's eyes widened as he took in the sight, staring at Mydei where he stood at Phainon's side.

"Mydeimos?"

Mydei's throat bobbed. When he spoke, it was hoarse, and Phainon was surprised at how strained it sounded.

"Krateros."

Chapter End Notes

dun dun dun

thanks for reading!
- ogg :3

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

tehehehe i'm back :P

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Krateros.

Phainon knew why that name sounded familiar. He had just heard it for the first time, only a few days ago.

My teacher, Mydei had said.

The teacher Mydei hadn't seen since before he left Castrum Kremnos, ten years ago.

Mydei was still staring at Krateros, frozen with shock and uncertainty. It was silent for several long, thudding moments.

Until Krateros stepped forward—one step, then two, and then all of a sudden he was kneeling at Mydei's feet.

"You're alive," Krateros breathed in relief.

Mydei still had not moved, but those words must have broken his hesitation, and he moved a hand to Krateros' shoulder.

"Do not kneel for me, old friend," Mydei said quietly.

Krateros rose to his feet. Now that he was standing closer, Phainon could make out his features—he was older, features grizzled with age and heavily scarred, remnants of the Kremnoan legacy present on almost every visible patch of skin. He wore the same dark crimson that Mydei did, edged in gold with foreign designs woven through the fabric of his chiton.

Seeing Mydei and Krateros side by side, Phainon felt as though the legendary kingdom of Kremnos had come back to life, standing in front of him like a fairy tale made real.

Mydei did not seem like he knew what to say, and neither did Krateros. It had been ten years since their last meeting, after all, so Phainon supposed it was understandable that the words they might have said once could have gotten lost along the way.

Aglaea spoke. "Please, feel free to stay here as long as you need. I imagine you might have some catching up to do." With that, she moved to depart, catching Phainon's eye as she

passed.

Phainon understood. This was not the time to stick his nose where it didn't belong. He turned and went to the lift with Aglaea, watching Mydei's back as the lift descended.

Aglaea and he were silent until they reached a quiet balcony of the palace where they could speak freely. When they arrived, Phainon recounted the events of their ill-fated mission, wincing as he told her about how he had been incapacitated with fever during most of it. Aglaea did not blame either of them for losing the smugglers' trail within the tunnels, only acknowledged how shrewd the smugglers had been in choosing the location of their base.

After that, it was silent. Phainon didn't know how to ask what he wanted to, so he said nothing. As always, though, Aglaea knew what thoughts brewed behind his thin facade, and spoke first.

"The Kremnoan detachment arrived yesterday, seeking refuge from the black tide after their settlement was destroyed."

The black tide had been creeping closer and closer to Okhema in recent years—it was the very disaster that had destroyed Phainon's home, yet still it spread chaos and destruction across the earth, no end to its vicious reign in sight.

Okhema had become a sort of refuge, taking in victims displaced by the black tide's wrath, but the city walls were only so tall, the stones only so strong. One day, it would fall to the black tide. Phainon could only hope it wouldn't be soon.

Phainon wondered. "Do they know? That Mydei—that Mydeimos is here?"

Aglaea shook her head. "No. Just Krateros. You saw him."

"But they'll know now."

"I assume so, yes. Mydeimos… I cannot protect him anymore. This city knows him, and it is only a matter of time before his people learn he is here."

"What will happen to him?" Mydei's people must believe he abandoned them. Would they be angry? Would they demand answers?

"That, I do not know."

Phainon wanted to know what Mydei was feeling at that moment. He excused himself and returned to his apartments, his appetite gone. All he could think about was Mydei.

Mydei had left his people after the fall of Kremnos to live his own life and escape the fate that shackled him to a ruined kingdom. Now that his people were here, in Okhema, what would happen? Would Mydei be once again forced under the burden of leading his people? But Kremnos no longer existed, had been gone for a decade.

Would Mydei be allowed to go free? To live for himself?

Phainon couldn't free his thoughts from this perilous chain of thinking, and he ached restlessly for hours. No news came from Mydei or Aglaea, and Phainon found himself going to eat dinner on his own in the market, jittery with uncertainty.

He had just sat down at an unoccupied table beside the market stall to eat his bowl of stew when he heard a group of people rustling to sit down at the table behind him. They were being loud, and as much as Phainon tried to ignore them he was ultimately unsuccessful.

Perhaps that was for the better, for what they were talking about made him stop dead, the spoonful of stew that had been halfway to his mouth freezing in midair.

"What's taking Krateros so long?" one of them grumbled.

"Who knows? It's not like complaining about it will do any good."

"Forgive me if I don't want to spend more time in this damned city. It's bad enough Krateros led us here."

"Where else would we go, Nikias? If you haven't noticed, there aren't that many places untouched by the black tide nowadays," another piped in, sounding annoyed.

"Perhaps, but Okhema?" Nikias hissed. "You know what they think of our people. We'd be better off almost anywhere else, black tide be damned."

Phainon's heart felt impossibly loud. These were Mydei's people. He shoveled the stew down his throat. He couldn't stand worrying about Mydei any longer, and finished his dinner as fast as he could stomach.

Without looking behind him, Phainon left the market, and went searching for Mydei.

He wasn't in the baths. The Hero's Bath was empty, as was Aglaea's office—Phainon had peeked in guiltily, not wanting to snoop where he wasn't allowed, but the room was empty. He checked the canteen, too, but Mydei wasn't there.

Besides Mydei's apartments, where Phainon had never been, that only left one place.

When Phainon arrived at the training arena, Mydei was sitting on one of the wooden benches surrounding the ring. The tension in Phainon's heart released somewhat, a tightness he didn't realize he was carrying. Outwardly, Mydei looked fine, but Phainon knew that didn't mean the inside was necessarily the same.

Mydei looked up as Phainon came over to sit beside him.

"Are you okay?" Phainon asked.

Mydei gazed at him. "I don't know," he answered.

Phainon reached over to clasp his shoulder, squeezing it firmly. He said nothing for a moment, letting his hand rest on Mydei's shoulder, and Mydei did not brush it away.

After a moment, Mydei spoke again.

“He doesn’t blame me for leaving.”

“Krateros?”

Mydei nodded. “He said…he understood. That I needed to leave.”

Phainon said nothing.

“I spent so long wondering what I would say if I ever saw him again, saw my people again. I ended up not being able to say a thing. He said he was hurt, in the beginning, that I didn’t tell him. He said he forgave me.”

Mydei’s gaze returned to where it had been, looking upwards toward the stars as he so often did.

“But my people did not.”

Phainon thought of Nikias, of the Kremnoans he had heard at the market. Were they still waiting for the day their prince would come to unite his kingdom, for the day Strife would return to the earth?

“Ten years is a long time,” Phainon said. “Do they still cling to their hopes of returning home?”

“I don’t,” Mydei responded. “But I never did. I left to forge my own path, after all.”

Phainon thought of his own yearning, the ache he felt whenever he remembered Aedes Elysiae, how much he wished to return to that idyllic time.

“I would. Cling, I mean. I still do.”

“To tell the truth… I think I do, too. I never truly wished for the crown, never wished to bear the burden of Strife—but Kremnos was my home,” Mydei said wistfully. “If there was someone in front of me who had the power to bring me home, I would cling on to them, too.”

Mydei’s hand reached up to grasp Phainon’s where it still sat on his shoulder.

“What should I do?” he asked quietly, almost whispering as he looked over at Phainon.

“What do you want to do?” asked Phainon, softly.

Mydei’s golden eyes rippled with remorse, guilt, and finally—resolve.

“I want to stay.”

“Then stay.”

Mydei squeezed his hand, then released it, his gaze returning to the night sky.

“I hope I can,” he said. “But…”

Phainon’s heart missed a beat.

“But?”

“I need to set my people free, first,” Mydei finished.

“How?” Phainon wondered.

Mydei let out a soft breath. “Krateros said I should do what I think is right. Letting my people continue to hold on to a fantasy is cruel. They need to be shown that it is time to move on.”

“He sounds wise,” Phainon said.

Mydei nodded. “He is. He taught me to read, to fight—everything I know, I learned from him.”

“Would he support you, then? In freeing your people?”

“I believe so, yes.”

“Then I agree. Do what you feel is right, Mydei,” declared Phainon.

The corners of Mydei’s mouth twitched up into a smile.

“I think I will.”

Chapter End Notes

thanks for reading! :3

- ogg

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

> writing this fic is turning me into a habitual lore reader… i used to be too lazy to read lore but not anymore ig… the lengths i will go to for yaoi
>
> p.s. updated the summary for this work to better reflect the story o.O

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next morning, Phainon was only somewhat surprised to see that Mydei was not at their usual spot in the training arena when he arrived. Phainon trained regardless, needing to feel his body move through the familiar motions of his routine. He had a hunch he would need some grounding before whatever Mydei decided to do happened.

Since Mydei wasn't there, Phainon knew he must have made up his mind.

Phainon couldn't help but feel the threads of anxiety slither into his mind, but it was outweighed by the trust he had in Mydei. Mydei would do what was best—and as for what that was, only Mydei knew. This both soothed and worried Phainon, but he tried his best to focus on his forms, stubbornly setting his mind elsewhere to avoid falling into his thoughts.

The dam broke after breakfast. Phainon was finishing up his meal in the marketplace when a courier came with a summons from Aglaea.

All Chrysos Heirs must be present, the courier had said.

Phainon's pulse felt too quick. This was it.

He made his way to the Hero's Bath, and found the rest of the Chrysos Heirs had all arrived before him, gathered in Aglaea's office. Castorice, Hyacine, Cipher, the Tribioses, even Professor Anaxa—Phainon hadn't known the professor was even in Okhema at the moment. Even so, his heart gladdened to see all of them together again.

Mydei stood beside Aglaea, the morning sun filtering through the large windows, casting radiant beams of light upon his golden hair.

Like a crown of gold, Phainon thought to himself.

Mydei greeted him with a slight nod, his head aglow at the movement. Then, Aglaea spoke.

"Thank you all for coming here so early in the day. I hope all of you have eaten, for this will not be a particularly short meeting. Today," she cast her gaze upon Mydei, standing by her side, "Mydeimos has something to say."

Mydei did not falter as all the eyes in the room swung onto him. He stood straight, posture upright and regal, no trace of hesitation in his gaze as he spoke.

"I have not been truthful about who I am."

And so he told them. Mydei spoke about who he truly was, how he came to leave Kremnos, and how he found himself in Okhema. Mydei spoke the longest he ever had to anyone besides Phainon, and even though Phainon knew everything already, had been the first to know, his heart still thudded painfully with the knowledge of Mydei's burdens.

The son of Strife, now in service to his kingdom's age-old enemy.

And yet, Mydei wanted to stay. Perhaps that was what gave Mydei the courage to make this proclamation, to resolutely face his past in front of everyone around him—Mydei was not a cowardly man, but Phainon knew just how long he had been wandering in avoidance of his birthright.

After Mydei finished, he said nothing more, but did not leave either. He did not lower his head as if awaiting judgement, only looked upon all of them, at all the people he avoided knowing, the people he would have rather kept from knowing himself.

Cipher was the first to speak. "So the little lion was a prince all along, hmm? I should have seen that coming."

After that, it was like all of the tension hissed out of the room, and all of them spoke at once.

"De… You've been here so long and didn't feel like you could tell us, huh. I wish… I wish you knew how much we care about you!" said Tribbie, a little teary.

Trinnon piped up, "Yeah! It's okay you couldn't tell us… We don't care about that. We just want to support you, and even though you're a prince that won't change!"

The corners of Mydei's eyes crinkled as he looked down at the three Tribioses, his eyes softening with warmth. Phainon was amazed to see that Mydei was actually *smiling*. Phainon had seen the sight only a few times before, and was shocked that Mydei was smiling here, in front of the Chrysos Heirs.

Something in Phainon disliked seeing Mydei smile so freely, in front of people he scarcely knew, as if his smile should belong to quiet moments alone—not a resource to be handed out so easily. And yet Mydei's smile brightened him, made him shine so intensely, so much so that Phainon couldn't keep following that train of thought. Still, a strange feeling nested within Phainon as he watched Mydei.

Amidst the hubbub, Castorice made her way to Phainon's side. Phainon greeted her with a quick smile, but his gaze quickly returned to Mydei.

Seeing he was not going to speak first, Castorice spoke up.

"You knew already, didn't you?"

Phainon tore his eyes from Mydei and looked at her, a small smile returning to his face, this time one of guilt.

"...Perhaps."

Castorice let out a small sigh, folding her arms in front of her. "You two always were close. I should have known you'd be keeping secrets from the rest of us."

"They were Mydei's secrets, not mine," Phainon protested halfheartedly, but not with any real emphasis behind his words. He felt as though a great weight had been lifted from his heart, seeing all of his friends and fellow companions receive Mydei with such care. He hadn't really thought Mydei would ever be rejected by any of them, but it still brought warmth to his chest to see it unfold.

"I know," Castorice said, turning to face Phainon, looking him in the eye. "I'm just…really happy to see you the way you are now. Both of you," she glanced in Mydei's direction. "I didn't like to see you so unhappy… Before you left, I mean."

Phainon knew she meant before he and Mydei had left on their cursed mission to the smuggler's caves. A lot had changed in such a short time, and Phainon felt so full, with the knowledge that he had someone such as Mydei around him.

"I'm glad to see him this way, too," Phainon answered honestly. Surrounded by the Chrysos Heirs, the Tribioses pulling on his gauntlets, Aglaea's eyes glimmering with mirth, Professor Anaxa standing haughtily out of the way of the commotion—Mydei was still there, smiling, being seen for the man he truly was. Not his past, but not just a reflection of all Mydei wanted to be, either—all of it.

Mydei looked...at peace.

At that moment, Mydei looked up, his gaze connecting with Phainon's, and the golden light of the morning sun reflected off of Mydei's hair once again, blinding Phainon, causing him to wince and blink away in avoidance. When he looked back up again, Mydei was still looking at him, the corners of his lips pulled up in a smirk as he *snorted*.

Phainon felt affronted. Mydei was laughing? At him? He turned to Castorice instead, forcing away the childish impulse to pout. His heart felt too fast, as if he'd been running.

Phainon could only stand by the side with Castorice for the remainder of the meeting.

The announcement was planned for later the same day, at the height of Ascent Hour. That did not give the Heirs much time to plan, but all of them sprung into action to begin preparations. Even Anaxa stepped up, refusing to stand by even though he had little relationship with Mydei other than in the color of their blood—Anaxa had not been to Okhema since before Mydei's arrival, so the two had never crossed paths.

And yet, Anaxa surprisingly did not bristle when Aglaea requested he deliver the invitation to the detachment. Normally, the cantankerous professor would turn up his nose at tasks that he

deemed beneath him, usually when they had no relation to his research, but this time he only agreed amicably.

Phainon was astounded. He had never seen the professor seem so… Was 'passive' the correct term in this case?

He found a moment, in between his own rushed duties that morning, to ask the professor before he set out to meet Krateros.

"Professor… I'm curious. Why…"

"Why am I assisting in this endeavor? I am not so obstinate a man, Phainon."

There was nothing Phainon could say that was polite to that, so he kept his mouth shut.

"I only wish to wrap things up here smoothly so that I may return to the Grove. I do have a responsibility to this city, and I don't know where you get the idea that I want Okhema to fall to ruin while I'm not around. If this doesn't go well, and Okhema burns to ashes due to the heat of Kremnoan flames, where else would I get my research funding?"

Phainon should have known. He sighed, and went back to his duties.

When the time finally slipped by into Ascent Hour, the chimes tolling in the distance, Phainon steeled his heart, readying his mind.

It was time for Mydei to meet the detachment.

Only Phainon and Aglaea were to accompany him, as the nature of Mydei's proclamation had little to do with the Chrysos Heirs as a whole. Phainon would only be there as Aglaea's unofficial successor; if Aglaea hadn't been preparing him to lead the Heirs once she lost what remained of her humanity, even Phainon would not be present.

Phainon hurried to the room they had arranged to meet in. Mydei had said that in the time preceding the fall of Castrum Kremnos, the Kremnoan detachment was at its height, with hundreds of troops marching under Mydei's banner. After Kremnos fell, the detachment did not disperse, but many left to live their own lives, wandering as Mydei had across the earth in search of a new beginning.

Still, though, there were those who remained. The detachment today was dozens strong, still led by Krateros, who had been unwilling to abandon the remains of his people. During Mydei's talk with Krateros, the latter had told him that the detachment had found a town willing to take them in, where they settled down. It was three years after Kremnos' fall, and they set up camp, aiding the village and slowly creating a home of their own.

It had been peaceful, Krateros said. But nothing lasted forever—for what village could hope to defend against an enemy as shapeless and vindictive as the black tide?

Seven years after rebuilding their home from scratch, the Kremnoans were once again forced to watch as their home burned to the ground.

That is how the detachment now found its way to Okhema, and back to its crown prince. If Phainon were Kremnoan, he would feel it was some machination of fate, that Mydei would truly be the one to deliver their salvation and bring them back home, restoring Kremnos to its rightful glory.

Phainon's chest twinged. He shook it off as he finally arrived at his destination, standing outside the grand doors emblazoned with a golden sun for a moment to catch his breath.

Then, steeling his resolve, he pushed in.

Aglaea had not yet arrived, and neither had Mydei. The feasting hall was filled with dozens of soldiers garbed in various shades of red and brown. Many of them looked in high spirits, jeering and laughing over each other.

But still there were those that were quiet; as he walked towards the front of the hall, Phainon noticed a group noticeably out of place near the front of the room, faces grim as they murmured amongst themselves.

He had little time to acclimate himself to the boisterous atmosphere, however, as just then Aglaea entered from a door across the hall with Krateros, walking over to where Phainon stood. Krateros acknowledged him with a courteous nod, and Aglaea passed her gaze over him noncommittally.

The hall quieted as the soldiers noticed the appearance of their superior, but was not entirely devoid of noise, mumbled whispers and laughter still audible across the large room.

Then, the door from which Aglaea had entered swung open once again, and Mydei stepped into full view of the detachment.

The hall went silent. Mydei approached the front of the hall and addressed them all.

"I am Mydeimos, Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos. Today, you shall witness me accept my birthright as king of Kremnos."

The hall erupted with noise, expressions of shock and disbelief present on the Kremnoans. Phainon noticed how the group in the front of the room did not join the commotion, but their faces darkened with anger as they recognized their prince.

Mydei spoke again, his voice carrying over the noise, although he had not spoken any louder than before.

"My first decree as king will also be my last. The Kremnoan dynasty ends here."

The hall was suddenly silent again, the soldiers shocked into a mute daze. Then—

"You abandon your people, your birthright, just like this? How can you call yourself a true Kremnoan as you run away from your duty?" came an angry voice from the soldiers. It was one of the soldiers who had looked angry at Mydei's arrival, who had not joined the others in loudly voicing their surprise.

And… Phainon recognized that voice. It was one of the voices he had heard in the market the day before—*Nikias*. The one who had sounded disgusted by being forced to crawl to Okhema for aid, the home of their greatest enemy.

Mydei looked at Nikias impassively, no trace of anger or guilt in his expression.

"I have never wished to carry on the glory of Strife. It destroyed my father, and it destroyed the legacy of Kremnos. There is no honor to be found in bloodshed, only pain. I only wish for all of you to live for yourselves as you have never done, as your kinsmen have done—as I have done."

Nikias glowered, still standing in opposition to Mydei.

"That is not who we are. Kremnoans were born to follow Strife, would rather die than run from their birthright, tails between their legs," he hissed. Nikias' face was red, but he still spoke clearly and loud enough for the entire hall to hear, every word dripping with contempt.

"The prince who abandoned us once is abandoning us once again. Legends speak of the sting of betrayal, but there was never a betrayal as legendary as this," Nikias spat. "I would never abandon our people, nor become as cowardly as you, Mydeimos."

With that, Nikias spun on his heel and marched out of the feasting hall, half a dozen others following him out.

Then, it was silent once more.

Chapter End Notes

pacing? we don't know her

thanks for reading!
- ogg :3

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

womp womp more whump

aka author whump time bc why did i have to catch a cold in the middle of august and get my period at the same time… phaidei save me T.T. anyway enjoy this monster of a chapter

some cws for this chapter, please go to the end notes to read them!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After a few moments, it did not seem like there would be any more outbursts. Mydei simply stood silently, not offering any more explanation than he already had. The hall felt humid, tension thick in the air.

Krateros moved first. Without saying anything, he turned from beside Mydeimos to face him, and then fell to one knee, head bowed. For a beat, nothing happened, and then—

As if they had only been waiting for permission, the Kremnoan detachment followed suit, kneeling to Mydei.

It was not all at once, but rather staggered; Phainon could see the less fervent soldiers at the back hesitate for a moment, but by the end there was not a single Kremnoan soldier who was not kneeling.

The Kremnoans bowed to no one but their leader—their king.

Mydei's people had forgiven him, after all.

Phainon's chest swelled with emotion. Besides Nikias and his group of radicals, it seemed Mydei did not need to fear his people's derision. They might still be angry, upset at Mydei for finding his own place, but still they knelt.

Mydei looked over his people, and if Phainon knew him any less, he might have missed the glint of triumph in Mydei's eyes.

After, food was brought out, and they all ate together. Aglaea had made sure to prepare the *ariston* in advance, planning for the possibility that all would go well. Phainon hadn't entirely known what to expect, but he was glad the meeting with the detachment hadn't ended in bloodshed.

Phainon sat at Mydei's table, with Krateros and Aglaea, and they were joined by an endless stream of soldiers as they cycled by, wanting to catch the attentions of Mydeimos himself. No matter that Kremnos no longer stood, and Mydeimos had been a king for less than a quint—the soldiers looked at Mydeimos like he was made of the sun itself, as if stars would fall from the sky if he only willed it.

Through it all, Mydei talked, clapped shoulders, even huffed out a short laugh or two. From where he sat across the table, Phainon could hear when he slipped into the foreign sounds of what must be Kremnoan with his comrades, speaking lowly and intimately with some, raucously and boisterous with others.

It was a long time before the food had been cleared away and the line of Mydei's admirers receded, leaving Phainon thoroughly exhausted. He excused himself when he saw there was nothing left for him to do, planning on returning to his apartments to sleep before evening duties. Mydei was still speaking with Krateros as Phainon left, the doors swinging shut behind him.

Phainon was almost home, taking the quickest route through the city's back alleys when he heard it—a muffled shout, and a thud, accompanied by jeers. Phainon followed the noise and rounded a corner into a narrow alley, running into a group of men.

One of them was on the ground, covered in dirt and blood, and the others stood over him, garbed in familiar robes of crimson.

"Oh, look, it's Mydeimos' little bitch," Nikias said, his voice dripping with condescension. He was leaning against the alley wall, looking at Phainon with a nasty glint in his eye.

"Violence is prohibited inside city walls," Phainon said, eyes narrowing. "Disperse."

One of the other men scoffed. "What are you gonna do, *Deliverer*? We are not Okheman citizens—you cannot punish us, no matter how much you wish to."

Phainon's voice came out harder than he meant it to. "Okheman or not, you are still subject to Okheman laws."

Nikias pushed off the wall, stepping closer to Phainon. "Again, what are you gonna do?" he sneered. "If I say this man attacked us first, you wouldn't believe me, would you? You'd say that I started it, that because I'm Kremnoan that I must have thrown the first punch."

"You don't know that," Phainon said. "Regardless of who punched first, you shouldn't have returned it."

Phainon moved to pick up the man from the ground, and was startled to see that it was Hesiodos, the man who oversaw the dromas workshop. The older man's face was darkened with dirt and blood, his left eye blackened.

"Hesiodos," he murmured, astonished. "Are you all right?"

The old man lifted his head weakly. "Yes," he breathed.

Phainon's chest throbbed. Hesiodos had always been kind to Phainon—he'd always greet Phainon with a smile when he passed by, or offer him fruits from his garden as payment for helping around the workshop.

"Are you well enough to return on your own?"

"Yes," Hesiodos nodded. He started to hobble off in the direction of the market before he stopped, turning once more.

"Thank you, Lord Phainon."

Phainon watched him leave before turning back to the Kremnoans. Nikias and his gang hadn't left; they either hadn't been smart enough to scurry away while Phainon was distracted or were stupid enough to choose not to. Whatever the case was, they were still there, and Phainon was not in the mood to be polite for much longer.

Facing the Kremnoans, Phainon crossed his arms across his chest. "I cannot protect you from the consequences of your actions—I will have to question both you and Hesiodos to find out what happened. Regardless, you may be punished for raising your hand against a member of this city."

At the word "protect", Nikias' face screwed up into a scowl. "You wish to *protect* us, Okheman? What makes you think we need your flimsy protection?"

With that, Nikias stepped into Phainon's space, and Phainon's heart thudded dully in his chest. He didn't think Nikias truly wanted to harm him, but he had not brought his greatsword to the meeting with the detachment in the name of diplomacy—which meant he was very much unarmed. If Nikias wanted to harm him, Phainon would have to rely on his hands to stop him.

Nikias stepped forward until Phainon's back was against the alley wall. Phainon willed his face to remain impassive, but he had stupidly walked into this situation without an ace up his sleeve, and he felt the danger of it now.

"You are Mydeimos' people," Phainon said, looking Nikias in the eye. The other Kremnoans stood back, watching them, ready to fight if Phainon so much as breathed wrong. "I do not wish you to come to harm."

"Mydeimos' people… We are not *his* any longer," Nikias spat. "That traitor abandoned us once again. He has no claim over us any longer, nor on the throne of Kremnos."

Nikias shifted, and Phainon stilled as he felt the cold metal of a blade against his neck.

"How would dear Mydeimos feel if he found all of his new friends dead? Hmm?" Nikias dug the tip of the blade into Phainon's skin, and Phainon felt dizzy as he felt it break skin, the pain like lightning across his neck.

Fuck. He had to get out of here, now.

Phainon naively hadn't expected the situation to deteriorate this quickly, and his senses must have still been dulled by his fever the previous week to have failed to alert him to the current danger before it got to this level.

He couldn't die here, unarmed in an alley, far from anyone who would hear him cry out in pain.

He couldn't do that to Mydei.

Phainon's mind raced, trying to think of a way out of his current predicament, when he heard footsteps coming from the alley entrance. Nikias and the others clearly heard it too, and Nikias quickly lowered the blade from Phainon's neck, keeping it out of sight in between their stomachs.

Before Phainon could think about using this to his advantage, the person belonging to the footsteps came into vision, and Phainon was distracted by the sight of Mydei in front of him, his eyes on Phainon, eyes narrowing as he registered the nature of the situation.

Seeing Mydei distracted Phainon for a moment, and he shifted on his feet, forgetting for a moment the danger he was in. Phainon heard a quick gasp, and then realized the sound came from his own throat.

Phainon's breath caught as he felt a sharp, excruciating burst of pain, and he looked down, confused—until he saw Nikias' dagger where it rested hilt-deep in his abdomen.

He couldn't process it, couldn't really understand what was going on, but one moment Phainon was upright, the next he was on the ground, coughing out dirt where he had inhaled it. Nikias stood over him, face struck with horror, as if he hadn't actually meant to stab—*stab?*—Phainon.

Phainon had been stabbed.

Oh*, fuck*. Being stabbed fucking *hurt*.

Nikias was gone, the others were gone, all Phainon saw was Mydei. Mydei's face was in front of him, eyes wide, frantic. He was saying something but Phainon couldn't hear it, the blood in his head was rushing too loud, drowning out everything else.

Phainon's vision was going spotty. *Fuck*. This couldn't be it.

Phainon felt pressure on his hand, looked down to see Mydei's hand encircling it, squeezing it. The other was on Phainon's stomach, staunching the flow of golden blood. Mydei was frantic, his eyes searching Phainon's, his mouth still moving, words unceasing.

Slowly, Phainon's hearing returned, and he heard what Mydei was saying.

"You're stronger than this, Deliverer. You do not get to die here. Stay awake, just—stay awake."

Mydei's voice was thick, as if he was speaking through a lump in his throat. Hearing that, Phainon tried to shake off his daze and struggled to speak.

"I…"

Mydei looked at him, eyes unsure, fearful.

Phainon tried again.

"Not…going anywhere… Promise."

Mydei's eyes softened, and he squeezed Phainon's hand again, stronger. He said something else, but Phainon couldn't hear anything more, and all he saw was blackness.

For a while, all Phainon knew was pain.

The first time he woke up, all he could feel was red-hot fire across his abdomen, spreading from his chest to his navel. It burned, and Phainon thrashed to try to put the fire out, but that only made it worse, and he cried in search of relief until it came in the form of sleep, putting him out of his misery.

The second time, something cool was wiping across his face. Phainon wanted to see what it was but couldn't figure out how to open his eyes, and the darkness pulled him under again before he could remember.

The third time, someone was opening his mouth and pouring something in.

"Please swallow, Lord Phainon," they whispered. Phainon swallowed, and then slept.

The fourth time, Phainon woke up on his own. His eyes opened without issue, and he blinked, his eyes taking a moment to adjust to the light. He was in the Okheman infirmary, the blue- and white-striped beds a familiar sight from when he used to get in fights after training as a boy and had to come to the infirmary for pain-relief patches, or poultices for his wounds.

"Lord Phainon!" came a gasp from beside him. Phainon turned his head to see Hyacine, standing next to his bed where she stood fiddling with some vials, which she promptly put down in favor of holding his hands tightly.

"How are you feeling?" she asked, face knitted with concern, her green eyes blinking furiously.

Phainon went to speak and found his voice hoarse with disuse. "All right… I think."

That was true. He wasn't in much pain, besides the muted throbbing of his abdomen, and he didn't feel uncomfortable anywhere else.

"I'm so glad you're okay, Lord Phainon," Hyacine squeezed his hands, mouth turned down in a frown. "I…did my best, but you almost didn't… If you'd been stabbed just a little higher, I

might not have been able to heal you," she said, sounding like she was about to cry.

Phainon felt a rush of affection. Hyacine tried her best to heal every patient with a smile, and for her to be brought down so by Phainon's condition—Phainon felt sorry for having brought her to this state.

"But you did, Miss Hyacine. I'm sorry," he admitted. "I should have been more careful."

"You should have," came a voice from the door.

Mydei was standing at the door, arms full with what looked like gift baskets full of fruit and get-well charms.

Phainon couldn't say anything for a moment, his breath caught in his throat as he remembered his last moments with Mydei.

Mydei had looked so, so sad.

But Phainon hadn't broken his promise. He was still here.

Phainon sat up straighter in his bed as Mydei approached, setting the gift baskets on the nightstand closest to Phainon's bed.

Phainon attempted to break the silence, and couldn't help but tease.

"Decided to bring me some gifts, my dear Mydeimos?"

As much as he tried to make it sound lighthearted, the teasing fell flat, and came out clumsier than Phainon had planned.

Mydei didn't glare at him, but it was a near thing.

"Tribbie, Trianne, and Trinnon asked me to bring these over for you. Said you needed to take care of your health while you recovered."

"I'll leave you to it, then. I'll be back to check in on you later, Lord Phainon," said Hyacine with a small smile, releasing his hands as she left, saying hello to Mydei as she passed by.

Mydei greeted her with a nod, and Hyacine was gone.

Not saying anything, Mydei sat down in the chair next to Phainon's bed. Phainon felt the inexplicable urge to fill the silence, as he often did when things felt awkward.

"I—um, I'm…"

Mydei broke through his stuttering. "How…are you feeling?"

"Good. I mean, okay. It doesn't really hurt now," said Phainon, tripping over his words. He wanted to be honest with Mydei—too often, he told white lies in front of others to not make them worry. Things like, *I'm doing well*, or *I'm okay, don't worry*.

He didn't want to lie to Mydei.

Mydei affirmed this with a nod. "Hyacine said she gave you some medicine to ease the pain."

Phainon had figured; his body felt lazy in ways that could not be attributed to sleep, his muscles too slow to react. He was grateful for the relief from pain, and his torso throbbed almost in spite, as if Phainon's body could guess what his attention was focused on.

It was quiet between the two of them, and Phainon didn't know what to say.

Aren't you glad I'm not dead? I didn't break my promise and leave you behind, Mydei. Didn't I do well?

What in Kephale's name would Mydei say to that?

A bolt of inspiration struck Phainon. "Nikias…" he began.

"He turned himself in."

"*What*?"

"He said he hadn't meant to hurt you, and that he only wanted to scare you," Mydei said, eyes sharp in anger.

Phainon recalled the look on Nikias' face after he stabbed him, the horror and fear clear in Nikias' eyes. He believed Nikias' words—that was not the face of a man who wished to kill.

"Then… The others?"

"Followed Nikias. They are in Aglaea's custody as we speak."

"Did you…" Phainon couldn't stop himself from being nosy. "Know them? Before?"

Mydei sighed, moving his gaze upward to stare at the ceiling. "Did I? I might have. Nikias, I never met. The others… Menander, Aristeides—their names feel familiar. But Euphranor… I think I knew him." Mydei's voice was sorrowful as he sorted through long-forgotten memories.

"If my memories do not fail me, he was the son of one of my father's councilors. We played together, as children." Mydei frowned. "His father earnestly supported the king and his violent policies, but back then, Euphranor was only a child. He would not have known of such things. To think… He would stand before me now and oppose me, just as his father would have, were he around."

Phainon was suddenly reminded of the complexities of Mydei's upbringing, ones he could not hope to relate to. He frowned at the thought of Mydei having to confront old companions, standing at opposite banks of a rushing river, forced to be at odds due to no fault of his own.

Lost in thought, Phainon was suddenly brought back to awareness by the feeling of Mydei's finger poking the furrow of his brow.

“Do not worry for me, Deliverer, when you are in no position to do so,” said Mydei.

Phainon cast his head down, ashamed. Mydei’s statement gave him the courage to bring up what he hadn’t the courage to earlier.

“I’m sorry.”

Mydei did not ask what he was apologizing for, which made Phainon feel somewhat worse. But Mydei did not let him wallow, only replied, “You need not apologize for staying alive.”

“I was careless. If you had not been there, I—” Phainon’s throat threatened to close up, so he stopped mid-sentence.

“Hesiodos came and fetched me,” came Mydei’s reply.

Phainon stared at him. “What?”

“I was searching for you, and someone had seen you pass by that area, so I was close by. Then, Hesiodos came up to me and asked me to help you.”

Phainon had never felt so grateful for Hesiodos. If not for Mydei searching for him at that very moment, Phainon might not be having this conversation with him in the present.

He breathed out a sigh of relief, dropping his head in his hands.

“I’m just… Glad I didn’t have to break my promise.”

“You didn’t.”

Phainon looked up to see Mydei gazing at him softly, eyes devoid of the anger they had held previously. All of a sudden, his heartbeat felt too fast, his face too warm, and the memories of Mydei holding him to sleep while Phainon was in the throes of fever came to mind, unbidden.

Phainon flushed, and he turned his face away to hide, hoping Mydei couldn’t hear the stuttering pace of his heartbeat.

Luckily, Mydei hadn’t noticed—at least, he said nothing to betray his observations, so Phainon pushed those thoughts away as best he could, choosing instead to fiddle with the blankets.

Mydei surprised him yet again, however, as he reached over to grasp one of Phainon’s hands, holding it tightly. Phainon was startled into looking back up at him, and saw only immense care in Mydei’s eyes.

“Thank you,” said Mydei. “For keeping your promise.”

Phainon nodded, his mind too jumbled up to speak.

For now, that would be enough.

Chapter End Notes

cw: phainon gets stabbed, lil bit of violence starting from when phainon encounters nikias & co. in the alley

thanks for reading!
- ogg :3

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

> hoo boy has it really been almost a month... the daily grind has me within its clutches and i am powerless before it. please forgive me

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon was sentenced to bed rest for three weeks. Naturally, that meant he was walking around Okhema by the middle of the second, having whined and pouted his way into the nurses' sympathies, who finally gave in and let him out of bed when they couldn't stand his lonely, mournful expressions any longer.

Although he was upright, he was still forbidden from strenuous activity until Hyacine approved, meaning not even the city guards were willing to risk the healer's stern retaliation by allowing Phainon into the barracks or the training arena.

Even Mydei did not give in, casting Phainon an even glare when he suggested a light spar after lunch one day. Phainon knew Mydei well enough to know that he was fighting a losing battle, and begrudgingly gave up, choosing to walk away instead.

In this way, the months slowly passed, the painted leaves of autumn giving way to the smell of damp and decay, finally settling into the brisk chill of early winter. Phainon's wound had mostly ceased its throbbing, only making its presence known when he pushed himself too much, or lifted something too high above his head. He considered himself mostly fully healed, but the *mostly* part of that statement hurt his pride more than he wanted to admit, and so he didn't mention that fact to anyone else.

The Kremnoans had not left. Not even after Nikias' assault on Phainon, which nearly drove the Kremnoans out of the city in shame—Aglaea had welcomed the Kremnoans into Okhema with open arms, offering protection and belonging to whomever wished to stay.

Phainon saw them about the city increasingly often now, relaxing in the public baths or taking meals in the market. Slowly but surely, the Kremnoans were making themselves comfortable in the foreign city.

Not to say that it was a painless process—the Chrysos Heirs had needed to resolve many more disputes as the Kremnoans learned how to coexist with the Okheman citizens, and so Phainon had practically mediated more legal disputes in the last several weeks than in his entire career.

As for Nikias, he was originally supposed to have been exiled for assault of a Chrysos Heir, but instead he had spent only a few nights in the city jail. To everyone's surprise, it was Phainon who had requested the lighter sentence—Phainon did not believe Nikias intended to

injure him, and that stabbing Phainon was a mistake borne out of fear and anger. A dangerous mistake, but a mistake nonetheless.

Still, Phainon hadn't seen Nikias since.

Now, the month of Fortune was halfway gone, and Phainon was looking forward to the festival held every year on the last week of the frosty month, when the city streets would fill with street vendors and the smell of treats roasted with honey, or the heady scent of spiced wine and seasoned lamb. Last year, Phainon and Castorice had roamed the busy streets in search of the best spiced wine, and were only distracted from their quest when they were drunk enough to have forgotten the reason for their excursion, giggling and stumbling through the city without a care in the world.

This month was under the rule of Zagreus, and so at first glance the month of Fortune would appear to be a misnomer, but instead it was the month of gamblers and chance. Whether your fortune was good or bad, this month would make it known, and the Festival of Fortune was full of fortune-tellers and games of luck, with everyone eager to see how their futures would unfold.

Phainon loved it. It always made for a festive atmosphere, and it was one of his favorite times of the year. He and Castorice had invited Mydei along this time, and Mydei, quite surprisingly, did not turn up his nose at the invitation, only huffing out a noise of affirmation.

When the first day of the festival arrived, Phainon left for the marketplace after dinner, where the heart of the festivities were set up. The streets were blanketed with snow, the light of the lanterns strung up throughout the streets and alleys reflected cheerily upon it, making it seem as if the entire city was bathed in gentle, golden light.

Merchants always went all out for the Festival of Fortune, working as hard as they could to pull in customers during the festival. Everywhere Phainon looked, he saw colorful lanterns and paper ribbons strung up above the dozens of stalls. Already, the festival was bustling with people, the atmosphere a pleasant hum.

Phainon's breath frosted in the air as he breathed out, tugging his woolen himation tighter to his body. He had planned to meet Castorice and Mydei at the entrance to the market, but the two of them were nowhere to be seen.

Right as Phainon decided to find himself a better vantage point to look for them, he felt a presence behind him, and turned to see the very people he had been looking for.

"Finally!" grumbled Phainon. "I almost froze to death waiting for you two."

"Oh, sorry. I ran into Mydei on the way, and we got distracted," said Castorice, not sounding sorry in the least for Phainon's plight.

"Hmmph." Phainon turned to Mydei, who despite the chill was barely dressed warmer than his usual attire, only donning a thin woolen cloak over his light chiton.

Did Kremnoans not get cold? Perhaps the true heat of Kremnos was hidden within the blood of their king.

Phainon's teeth chattered. He felt slightly envious of not needing piles of layers to keep warm, but shoved the thought away.

"Let's get going."

The atmosphere of the festival was as cheery as ever, and Phainon felt refreshed almost immediately. The past weeks had gotten increasingly busy, what with managing the Kremnoans and preparing for the month of Fortune, which always brought its own challenges as people settled debts, made new investments, or renegotiated contracts.

The three of them bought treats to snack on as they wandered through the market, Phainon and Castorice opting to grab mugs of spiced wine as well, while Mydei chose to drink warmed pomegranate juice instead, requesting the seller to add some fresh goat cheese.

When Phainon made a face at that, Mydei offered Phainon a sip, to which Phainon hurriedly refused. *Maybe next time*, Phainon said, knowing there would most definitely be no day where he tried *that* particular combination.

In the middle of the packed streets were various street performers. When they happened upon a bard strumming their lyre, singing a doleful tune, they stopped to listen for a while. It was a retelling of an ancient myth, tragic and heartwrenching. When the last note of the song rang out through the air, the crowd of people who had gathered to listen burst into enthusiastic applause.

After that, the bard launched into a joyful melody, the story a comedic tale of a mouse's birthday celebration gone wrong, complete with uninvited guests, forgotten presents and decorations that kept disappearing.

The song made Phainon chuckle, and he turned to Mydei, mind suddenly consumed with a question he had never thought to ask.

"That reminds me, Mydeimos… When is your birthday? I don't recall you ever mentioning it."

Mydei replied after a moment, "It…passed. Last month."

Phainon startled. "Last month?"

"It was the day after the first snow."

"…Ah."

Phainon didn't know why he was upset by this.

"How did you celebrate it?"

Mydei tipped his head up, remembering.

“We ate dinner together. Me and Krateros.”

“Oh. That’s…good.”

That’s good you didn’t spend it alone, Phainon wanted to say.

For that was what had been bothering him. If Mydei hadn’t spent his birthday with Phainon, who else would he spend it with? He was not known to linger amongst others. But Phainon had forgotten—Mydei wasn’t alone anymore, not with Krateros and his people in the city.

Mydei must have sensed there was more hidden behind Phainon’s silence.

“Do not waste your time worrying about me, Deliverer. I am not one of those prattling fools who insist on being paraded around and pandered to on their birthday.”

Phainon still felt unsatisfied. He went to protest again but was interrupted.

“If this matter troubles you so, then I will save some time for you next year. That way, I can spend my birthday however you deem appropriate.”

Mydei’s words were sarcastic, but Phainon answered as if he did not pick up the underlying meaning behind his words.

“All right.”

To his credit, Mydei did not look surprised, only huffed out a quiet laugh through his nose.

“…All right, then.”

Belatedly, Phainon realized the space on his other side was suspiciously empty—Castorice was not beside him as she had been when they’d originally stopped to listen to the bard.

It took nearly half a quint to find her, as she had been corralled into a fortune-telling booth in a quiet alley not far from where they were watching the performance. She had apparently been enticed into entering with promises of a free divination, the merchant seemingly hell-bent on luring in a fresh customer. Unluckily for him, Castorice’s curse meant that she would not allow him to read her palm.

Castorice had been afflicted with a strange curse since birth; she could not touch others with her hands, unless she wanted to send them to an early death. However, the heavier the touch, the worse the effects—if she brushed against someone by accident, it wouldn’t kill them, only make them drowsy, but if her hands made direct, prolonged contact with someone’s skin, it would send them into a quick, albeit painless, death.

Phainon had learned very quickly to avoid touching Castorice casually, as the first few times he did it without thinking caused him to doze off right at the breakfast table.

In the end, the merchant ended up shooing them away, proclaiming bad luck in store for each of them, sore for the lack of profit to be made.

With that, they continued walking through the market, their contented breaths fogging out in front of them, visible manifestations of their presences on this cold, joyful evening.

When the air grew colder, and the lights of the festival began to blink out as stalls closed for the night, they decided it was time to go home.

They walked back together, and Castorice was the first to depart when they arrived at Marmoreal Palace. That left only Phainon and Mydei, alone in the darkness.

The city was quiet at night, the only noises being the occasional group of people returning to their homes from the festival, muted laughter and the crunch of boots on the snow.

Phainon said his goodbyes to Mydei, but found the other following him after he began walking away, and turned to face Mydei curiously.

Mydei stopped in his tracks, face impassive.

“I live this way as well.”

So they walked together, comfortably silent. Phainon’s heart and belly were content with the atmosphere of the festival, and he did not feel the need to fill the silence. They walked for a while, Phainon’s head lost in his thoughts until he realized they had passed Phainon’s apartments and were now in a corner of the city he wasn’t familiar with.

Phainon stopped in his tracks. They had arrived in an enclosed courtyard, the red door of a house barely visible through the branches of the snow-laden trees.

“Is this your house?” Phainon asked. He had never seen where Mydei lived before, and was curious.

Mydei nodded.

“Then… I should get back,” Phainon said, suddenly embarrassed. He hadn’t meant to keep walking with Mydei, lost in his thoughts, and the night was chilly. He shivered.

“All right.”

Mydei turned to go inside, and Phainon was struck with the urge to say something more before he left.

“Thank you for coming today.”

Mydei turned back, the hint of a smile visible through the crinkle of his eyes.

“I had fun. Thank you for inviting me.”

Possessed by a sudden need to make his feelings known, Phainon burst out, “You’re my closest friend, you know.”

Mydei didn't say anything immediately. And then, "I feel the same, Deliverer."

That was the answer Phainon had wanted, but somehow he was still restless. He didn't know how to express what he was feeling, so he just stood there, struck dumb.

It was silent for a few moments until Mydei spoke again, still staring at Phainon.

"If…there ever comes a day where I lose control, when Strife overtakes me, I want you to kill me."

Phainon stared.

"*What*," he whispered, his voice cracking.

Mydei stepped closer to Phainon and took his hand, guiding it to a spot slightly above the small of Mydei's back. Phainon could feel the heat of Mydei's skin through his cloak, the distant pulsing of his heartbeat.

"My tenth thoracic vertebrae. If you pierce my body here, I will die," Mydei said. "A true death—one my immortal body cannot evade."

Phainon couldn't move. He imagined his greatsword slicing through Mydei's flesh, a shower of golden blood spraying through the air, and then Mydei, limp and unmoving, never to rise again.

Phainon stepped away quickly, removing his hand from Mydei's back.

"No," he said. "I cannot."

"I would trust no one else with this," said Mydei.

Phainon did not want to think about Mydei dying. He knew Mydei had died before, but Phainon had never witnessed it—besides, Mydei had said this would be a "true death".

Phainon had lost enough.

"No," he said again, turning away from Mydei.

"Deliverer," Mydei stepped back into his line of sight, leading Phainon's gaze back to his own.

"Only you are my equal in this life. Only you can get close enough to kill me."

"I do not *wish* to kill you, Mydeimos!" Phainon roared. "There is no one I would rather kill less, and I would rather throw myself in front of another blade before I ran my sword through your back like a *coward*." These last words burst out of him with vicious force.

"*Phainon*," Mydei said firmly.

Phainon was trembling. He was angry, angry that Mydei did not see the weight of asking this of Phainon. He couldn't speak anymore, choked by a lump in his throat, so he stood silently, glaring at Mydei.

Mydei was still looking at Phainon with the same indifferent gaze he always wore. It should have made Phainon madder, but the longer Phainon glared at Mydei the more he felt his anger slip away like a piece of driftwood in a fast-moving stream.

Only you are my equal.

Mydei feared losing himself to Strife, feared losing the iron grip on his control as much as Phainon feared losing his own. Phainon pictured it suddenly—if Mydei were to lose sight of himself after bearing the coreflame, there would be no telling how great the devastation would be. Mydei was the strongest warrior Phainon knew, and although he had never lost control before, if the coreflame was too much, then who knows how far he would go in the throes of madness?

Phainon's throat was dry, so he swallowed.

"All right," he said hoarsely.

Mydei still held his gaze, unwavering.

"I'll do it."

Chapter End Notes

thanks for reading :3
- ogg

Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

> ahahaha… new tags guys… would you believe me if i said i did not honestly see this coming

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next few days kept Phainon busy, busy enough that he shouldn't have had time to worry about other things, but his promise to Mydei kept returning to his mind whenever he had a moment to himself.

It was infuriating, but no matter how many times Phainon replayed the conversation, he still did not feel any more at ease.

Phainon wouldn't go back on his promise, no—once he promised something, there was no chance of him failing to accomplish it.

It was just that Phainon didn't want to think of Mydei dying.

Phainon had seen a lot of death, had killed hundreds of monsters for his pledge to protect the Holy City, but never before had he killed an innocent—never before had he killed a friend.

He knew he needed to take these feelings and plunge them deeper into his chest, so deep they wouldn't come back to haunt him until later, as he did with most things that troubled him, but these particular feelings did not go easily.

For the time being, Phainon was stuck with this aching, claustrophobic feeling that came to mind whenever he remembered his promise to Mydei, which was often. So Phainon did as he did best—threw himself into his duties, volunteered for as many extra tasks as he could without collapsing, and forcibly filled his mind with nothing but work.

Fortunately for Phainon, it seemed to be working.

He didn't think about it while feeding the chimeras that morning. He didn't think about it while helping around the dromas workshop. He didn't think about it during the weekly briefing on the black tide, or while out on evening patrol, or while making himself dinner that night.

Luckily for Phainon—who hadn't been thinking about his promise to Mydei at all—he was soon presented with a pressing issue to solve.

The Kremnoans were planning to revolt.

Not all of them—several months had passed since the detachment's arrival in the Holy City, and the cracks in the system were beginning to show. The Okhemans were beginning to lose their patience in accommodating the newcomers; likewise, the Kremnoans were becoming frustrated with the cultural barriers as they acclimated to their new lives.

The last few days, there had been whispers in Okhema of overthrowing the false king of Kremnos, who had led the Kremnoans to a doomed existence in the city of their enemy.

"I don't understand," Phainon said in their next meeting. "If they don't like it here, why don't they just leave? Why revolt?"

Aglaea frowned. "It seems simple when you put it like that, but I'm afraid there must be more to it. Mydeimos?" she asked, deferring to the Kremmoan sitting to her left.

Mydei considered for a moment before speaking, his golden eyes narrowing. "When I accepted the throne of Kremnos, there were many who opposed me. Even though most of my people accepted my order for them to live in accordance with their own wishes, perhaps my authority is not as absolute as I once thought. If my people doubt their king's authority, then will they still follow his will?"

"Even if his will was for them to make their own choices?" Phainon asked.

"It seems as though no matter whether they accepted Mydei as their king then, they are struggling to accept his will now, now that they are encountering more issues in their daily lives," Castorice replied.

"Then it would seem they need a reminder," Phainon said. "Of who their king truly is, and whether he can be trusted to lead them to a better life."

"It would seem so," agreed Aglaea. "Does anyone have any suggestions?"

Silence. And then—

"A duel."

All eyes turned to Mydeimos.

"A duel between the king of Kremnos and Okhema's strongest warrior," said Mydei, as he turned to face Phainon, determination burning in his eyes.

Phainon's heart jumped. He would never refuse Mydei a duel, regardless of how high the stakes, but the thing he decidedly hadn't been thinking about the last several days still squeezed at his heart, causing him to pause.

"Phainon?"

"Yes," he blurted out.

Mydei nodded approvingly, his eyes never leaving Phainon. "Regardless of whether I win or lose, I know I can trust you to give me a worthy fight. I will prove to my people that my word

is still true through the glory of battle."

Later, Phainon asked Mydei something that had been on his mind the whole meeting.

"I thought you'd stepped away from the crown after your decree, Mydeimos."

Mydei leveled a gaze at him. "I had. But if that decree never truly reached the hearts of my people, I still see it as my duty to enforce it. I *will* show my people the way to freedom, whether they wish to follow it or not. But if they have lost their way, it is my responsibility to show them the path once again."

This made Phainon stop in his tracks for a moment, considering.

"But… Does this not mean that you will never stop being their king?"

"...That may be. But if that is what it takes to show them a new way, then so be it."

Mydei had wanted to set his people free so he could live a new life, but for that he had to willingly shackle himself to the fates of the Kremnoan people to lead them into a new era.

It was a contradiction for the ages. Phainon's head hurt.

After that, preparations for the duel began. It was scheduled for several days later, at the beginning of Entry Hour, so that word had enough time to spread through the nooks and crannies of Okhema, in hopes of attracting everyone they could to the match.

The day of the duel dawned bright and cold, the midwinter air biting as Phainon waited for the duel to begin. It was to be held in the dueling arena beside the barracks, which in recent years had been a popular venue for fighting tournaments and melees, as there was plenty of room for raucous crowds to gather in attendance.

Already, the stands were filled with Okhemans and Kremnoans alike, shades of blue and crimson mixing indiscriminately throughout the arena. Though the air was brisk, the sunlight was warm, and Phainon's excitement vastly outweighed any nerves that might have been brought on by the crowd.

Finally, the judges arrived—Aglaea, Krateros, and a representative of the Council of Elders, acting as a neutral party. Mydei had arrived not long after Phainon, so with the arrival of the judges, the duel could begin.

Aglaea strode to the center of the arena and addressed the crowd, which quieted at the first resonant tones of her voice.

"Citizens of Okhema and guests of our esteemed city, welcome. Today, we bear witness to a battle of glory and strength between these two Chrysos Heirs. This duel shall showcase the strength of body and mind of Castrum Kremnos and of our Holy City. The victor shall receive a crown of laurels to commemorate their victory. However, regardless of the winner, I hope that this duel will prove that these two sides can indeed find common ground, and find mutual strength in each other."

Raising her hand, Aglaea said, voice echoing throughout the arena, “Let the duel commence!”

With a blast of a horn, the duel began.

Normally, Phainon was the first to strike when they dueled, but this was the first time Phainon had been allowed to duel since being stabbed, and he was perhaps slightly out of balance.

It was immediately apparent that he had some catching up to do, as this time Mydei struck first.

Phainon was alert enough to not be caught by surprise, but his nerves tingled, alight with the change in pace. Mydei’s eyes glinted in anticipation as Phainon parried his strike, catching the shift in Phainon’s balance before he counterstruck, allowing Mydei to dodge unscathed.

Before Mydei had time to recover, Phainon took up the offensive, slashing at Mydei’s torso, but Mydei leaped back again, this time legs lashing out to sweep Phainon’s feet out from under him.

Phainon rolled with the momentum of the fall, rising on his knees to quickly block Mydei’s strike with the flat of his blade in the nick of time.

To anyone, they would look equally matched. Phainon knew it, and his blood buzzed with the thrill of the fight. He wanted to find out who would end up winning this time, far more than anyone watching in the stands.

Mydei’s eyes were brilliant, illuminated by the sunlight, and his immortal body gleamed with exertion, muscles rippling and twisting to avoid Phainon’s slashes, feet nimble and sturdy as they carried him through the steps of a dance only he knew.

He was beautiful like this, and Phainon felt once again as if he was locked in step with a being of legends, of divinity.

Phainon lost track of time, eagerly meeting Mydei’s blows with his own, until a horn blew and Phainon realized the day was over.

Curtain-Fall Hour had arrived, and the duel would be paused until daylight returned.

In bed that night, Phainon marveled. A whole day had passed, and yet he did not feel exhausted, only a little fatigued. He had never been one to slack on his training, but perhaps his stamina was heartier than he’d realized.

Phainon had expected to feel disappointed that he hadn’t been able to beat Mydei, though they had dueled all day. Instead, his entire body sparked with excitement.

Mydei was his equal in every way, matching him evenly strike for strike. They had fought for an entire day, and neither had won—and now, they got to do it all again tomorrow.

Phainon slept, spirit heartened by the thought. He would beat Mydeimos tomorrow.

Except he didn't.

By the end of the second day, both of them were drenched in sweat and blood, but still standing.

By the end of the fourth day, Phainon wondered if the duel would ever end.

By the end of the seventh, Phainon was exhausted, but he was still determined to win. He would be the one to overthrow Mydeimos and his authority—show Okhema and Kremnos both who was truly the strongest warrior between them.

By the end of the ninth day, Phainon thought he might die if they fought for much longer. Every slash of his blade felt like it took all of his strength, and he was struggling to keep his balance. Still, Phainon persisted, and made it through the ninth day as he had the others.

The tenth day dawned chilly and gray, the arena shrouded in a dense fog that would have made Phainon shiver if he was still in touch with his corporeal form. He could only feel the urge to keep fighting, to win—and if he was sure of anything, Phainon would make sure this duel ended today.

With a blast of the horn, the duel resumed.

Phainon both wanted the duel to finish and for it to never end, so that he might have a chance to be locked in this battle of unmatched skill and raw strength for the rest of his life. As much as his muscles ached in protest, his lungs screaming for air, Phainon would have kept fighting day after day if only to just keep seeing Mydei like this.

For this was Mydei in his true essence—a being forged of strength and fire, his every move as swift and deadly as the lion of his birthright.

Phainon had never seen this Mydeimos. Mydei had always been fierce when they sparred, yes, and he would never have insulted Phainon by holding back, but this Mydei was something different entirely—something ancient and powerful, unable to be restrained by man or Titans alike.

Something…divine.

At that moment, Phainon realized Mydei's tattoos were glowing.

The crimson tattoos swirling upon Mydei's body were smoldering, now a brilliant red, the same tint as a glowing hearth. Not only that, but Mydei's eyes, normally reminiscent of polished amber, were now the shade of burnished gold.

Upon noticing Phainon's faltering steps, Mydei looked down at his body, seeing the changes for the first time. Smirking in realization, Mydei called out a taunt.

"So even Nikador believes we should hurry this up."

Then, he flung his sword to the dirt, causing it to skid away, too far for him to retrieve without Phainon taking advantage of his weaponless condition.

“I can beat you faster with my hands, anyway.”

Snarling, Mydei pounced. He was quicker like this, refreshed as though they hadn’t been fighting for nine days straight.

Phainon struggled to evade Mydei’s blows, and was taken completely by surprise when Mydei flung out his hand and sent a flurry of crimson crystals flying toward Phainon.

He had no time to react, no time to process this new turn of events, and could only keep parrying. At first, Phainon had no hope of returning to the offensive, but soon he was able to avoid the crystals with ease, could sense Mydei’s next move and rush to meet him there.

At first, Phainon didn’t notice the red glow surrounding his body, nor the unnatural gleaming of his sword which had previously been dulled by the days of combat, but when he finally looked down and saw his arms ringed in a crimson aura, he didn’t have time to think about what it meant, only lunged at Mydei once more.

Phainon heard a maniacal chuckle, and somewhere in the back of his mind he realized it must have come from his own throat.

Gradually, the last of Phainon’s consciousness left him, and all he knew was the clang of steel meeting Mydei’s gauntlets and the thrill that grew intertwined with his heartbeat, pulsing happily with every shift of their feet upon the dirt.

In this way, the tenth day passed, and the horn blew, signaling the end of the duel for the day.

“Enough!” the representative from the Council of Elders cried out. “We will all die of hunger before this duel is decided. I wish to call for a draw.”

As the judges deliberated, Phainon stared at Mydei. The glow had mostly faded, but it was still there, outlining Mydei’s muscled figure with crimson. Mydei was staring right back, and Phainon knew his own glow must still be there, too.

”The judges have agreed. The result of this duel is a draw.”

There was the slight muttering of displeasure from the few spectators who must have remained, but Phainon wasn’t paying attention, his mind still hazy and red-tinted from the duel.

He couldn’t tear his eyes away from Mydei, who was shining under the moonlight with both a sheen of sweat and the remnants of his divine aura, whose eyes still remained on Phainon’s.

He couldn’t tear his mind away from the memory of their duel, the memory of Mydei meeting him at every strike, every movement of Mydei’s intertwining with his own.

They stood like that until everyone else had gone, with only the distant stars and the night wind to witness their presences.

Phainon didn't remember leaving the dueling grounds, or how he made it home, only vague impressions of him and Mydei stumbling up the stairs to Phainon's apartments, removing their clothes haphazardly and pulling their boots off without a care as to where they landed.

Phainon remembered pulling off Mydei's gauntlets, holding him steady as Mydei lost his balance, delirious and battle-drunk, cheeks red with exertion. He remembered pulling Mydei into his arms as they toppled onto the bed, remembered running his fingers through the golden strands of Mydei's hair as Mydei's mouth found his neck, languid and sloppy.

He remembered pushing Mydei into the bed, inhaling his scent as he bit into Mydei's skin, watching the crescents of broken skin close up in moments, and remembered biting more, until Mydei was shivering and moaning brokenly above him, fist tight in Phainon's hair.

Phainon remembered being on his back, Mydei sitting above him, braid undone and face flushed.

Equal, he remembered Mydei murmuring into Phainon's skin. *My equal*.

After that, Phainon remembered no more.

Chapter End Notes

.....slowly adds the smut tag to this fic

anyways thanks for reading!
- ogg :3

Chapter 14

Chapter Notes

> if u saw me accidentally post this chapter early no u didn't..... i totally didn't accidentally post two drafts at once, only noobs would do that smh
>
> anywho i hope the experience was not spoiled for those of u who got a lil sneak peek LMAO. i hope u enjoy <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon fucked up.

Phainon had *severely* fucked up.

He had awoken to the sun shining through the linen curtains, casting a warm luster onto the room. Phainon had felt sated, lazy in his comfort—until he noticed the presence beside him.

Mydei lay on the other side of Phainon's bed, golden hair wispy on the pillows, his normally impassive expression muted in sleep.

Phainon's heart thudded, and the spell was broken.

What had he done?

He couldn't remember anything at first, didn't recall anything past seeing Mydei's form shrouded in crimson—until the memories came back to him in a rush.

Them leaving the dueling grounds together. Mydei, hands tangled in Phainon's hair. Phainon, carving his teeth into Mydei's skin.

Phainon's heart threatened to stop, and he tried his best to be noiseless as he got up from the bed and went to wash his face.

When he returned to the bedroom, Mydei was sitting up, staring at Phainon.

Phainon didn't know how he could salvage this.

"I—" he began, and then stopped.

Phainon couldn't manage to say anything else, lost.

Mydei rose wordlessly. He began gathering his fallen clothing from the floor, and pulled on his boots without looking at Phainon.

Then, Mydei was gone.

“As for the blessing of Strife—”

Aglaea had called for a meeting not long after Entry Hour that day, intending on discussing the nature of the red glow that had surrounded both Mydei and Phainon during the duel. The Chrysos Heirs had collectively concluded that it must have been the result of a Titan’s blessing—Phainon had heard of loyal followers receiving divine favor in the form of a bountiful harvest, or coming into sudden and vast fortunes, but he had never seen it happen before his own eyes.

The Lance of Fury had apparently seen Mydeimos’ raw determination to best Phainon and sent him a blessing, granting him divine strength. Not only that, but Phainon had received Strife’s blessing as well.

Phainon registered this dully, but could not bring himself to focus on the conversation winding around him. He could only recall Mydei’s face as he left Phainon’s apartments that morning, the way he would not show Phainon his face as he walked out.

So even Nikador believes we should hurry this up.

Mydei had known the nature of the blessing from the beginning, and Phainon wondered if that meant he was resistant to the intoxicating effects Phainon had been on the receiving end of the day before.

Phainon recalled how it felt—dizzying, and freeing, as if every inhibition Phainon had ever constructed in his mind were felled in an instant. Were he in his right mind, Phainon would never have acted like *that* with Mydei.

He had never considered seeing Mydei that way, but now that he had, he couldn’t keep the thought of it out of his head.

Phainon dug his nails into his thigh, hard. Now was not the time, or the place.

But thoughts of Mydei lingered in Phainon’s mind through the rest of the meeting. Images of Mydei’s sleeping face, his mussed hair, but most insistent of all were Mydei’s eyes. Those golden eyes followed Phainon everywhere he went that day, no matter how much Phainon tried to shove them out of his mind as he went about his daily duties.

If the duel had achieved anything, it was that the appearance of Nikador’s favor had quelled all doubts of Mydei’s authority. No longer did the unhappiest Kremnoans look askance at the Okhemans, nor at the Chrysos Heirs—apparently assured of Mydei’s authority and therefore of Okhema’s trustworthiness, the few Kremnoans who had been threatening to overthrow their king had quieted down into reluctant submission.

Settling them down fully into Okhema would take a lot more time and effort, but for now, the Kremnoans were no longer an issue.

Phainon had gone the entire day pushing away thoughts of Mydei, so when Phainon saw a flash of golden hair turn a corner before him while walking through Marmoreal Palace after dinner, it took a moment for him to realize that it was the real thing.

Pulse racing, Phainon hurried after him.

“Mydei.”

Mydei did not turn around.

“*Mydei*,” Phainon said insistently.

At that, Mydei stopped, finally turning to face Phainon.

“...What.”

“Why did you leave?”

Mydei did not have to ask what he meant. They hadn’t spoken since that morning, and Phainon had felt like he hadn’t taken a deep breath all day for the tension.

“You didn’t want me there.”

“I… What?”

Mydei’s arms were crossed in front of him, the familiar position today seeming more like a barrier.

“Your face. You looked like you were about to apologize.”

Phainon had been. Mydei must have seen the confirmation in his face, for he made to turn around again and end the conversation. Seeing that, Phainon reached for Mydei’s arm, at the same time remembering the feel of Mydei’s skin under his touch, of the softness of his hair—

Mydei was staring at Phainon, an indescribable emotion flitting across his face as his eyes landed on Phainon’s grip on his arm.

“I—I’m sorry.” He was still going to say it, no matter whether Mydei wanted to hear it or not. “I shouldn’t have—shouldn’t have taken *advantage* of you like that—”

“*Fool*,” Mydei hissed, wrenching his arm out of Phainon’s grasp. “What do you think it *means* to be called an equal in Kremnos? Do you think me so weak as to *let* something happen to me that I did not wish to?”

With those confusing words, Mydei whirled back around and stalked away. Phainon watched him go, not knowing how to begin to process Mydei’s words.

Did that mean…?

Mydei had called him *equal*.

Phainon's head spun. He needed to confirm something.

He found the professor in the library. Head buried in a book, Anaxa did not even bother to look up at Phainon as he pointed him in the direction of books on Kremnoan culture. Phainon didn't take it personally—the professor had been conducting lots of experiments of late, seemingly due to an upcoming research presentation, so this state of intense focus was not an unfamiliar sight.

Phainon found the section on Castrum Kremnos with some difficulty; it was wedged between the folktale and geography sections, with only a sliver of the shelf belonging to Kremnoan customs. With a sigh, Phainon pulled out the small stack of books and plopped them onto a nearby desk, intending to pore through each of them until he found what he was looking for.

Phainon had not fully expected to find the answer in these books, but after only a little while of searching, he found it, hidden in a footnote in a book on the history of Castrum Kremnos.

Underneath a section on Kremnos' worship of Strife, the footnote read:

"As such, the Kremnoan worship of battle has become closely intertwined with matters of love; in Kremnos, a comrade or sparring partner can only dream to be called another's "equal", the highest form of praise in Kremnos, as equality on the battlefield is seen to be the foremost marker of harmony between two individuals."

Phainon closed the book, head spinning.

My equal, Mydei had said, under the influence of Nikador's blessing.

You are my only equal in this life, Mydei had said before their fateful duel.

Mydei had called him an equal, multiple times.

Phainon left the library in a hurry, mind full of thoughts of *equals* and *harmony*.

Before long, Phainon found himself standing outside Mydei's house, the painted red door the same as he remembered it, the trees bordering the courtyard still covered in snow.

He waited on Mydei's doorstep for a long time, until the shadows had completely overtaken the courtyard, and the air grew chilly. Eventually, he rested his head on his legs, which he'd pulled closer to his chest to stave off the cold. He must have closed his eyes at one point, and only woke to the noise of someone's footsteps on the snow before him.

He raised his head, strands of white hair falling to conceal his view.

He went to remove them from his vision, but the newcomer got there first, his leather gloves tucking the errant hairs behind Phainon's ear.

Mydei stood before Phainon, breath frosting out in front of him.

Phainon was invited inside, Mydei giving only a cursory glance at Phainon's condition before he demanded Phainon come in before he caught a cold.

Mydei's home was not terribly large, and cozier than Phainon would have expected, with rugs blanketing the stone floor and patterned curtains drawn across the windows. The fire was low, with a pot of soup bubbling over it, diffusing the scent of lemongrass and basil through the house.

Phainon held his tongue until after Mydei had given him a blanket and a mug of honey mead and sat him down squarely on a tufted couch.

"You called me your equal."

Mydei paused in his tidying of his living room for a moment, then resumed before sitting down beside Phainon.

"...Yes."

Phainon didn't back down.

"Did you mean it?"

Mydei looked him in the eyes, expression guarded.

"What are you truly asking?"

"*Did you mean it?*" Phainon pressed.

"Yes," Mydei did not hesitate this time.

Phainon let out a shuddering breath, before he took his courage in hand once more.

"Did you mean it when you said you'd never let me do anything you didn't want?"

Mydei's eyes narrowed. "I didn't mean that I'd let *you,* specifically—"

"*Did you mean it*?"

Silence. Then finally Mydei said, "Yes."

Mydei was looking down into his own mug of honey mead when Phainon's hands enclosed his, both of their hands wrapped around the mug.

Mydei looked up. Phainon had moved closer, so that their breaths were practically intermingled, their lips mere millimeters apart.

"Does that mean you'll let me do this?" Phainon whispered.

In answer, Mydei exhaled softly, his breath warm on Phainon's lips.

Then Mydei kissed him.

His lips were soft and warm and tasted like honey and pomegranate. Phainon couldn't stop his hands from moving to cup Mydei's face, brushing his thumbs over his cheeks as he kissed Mydei deeper.

The mug of honey brew was moved to the table, forgotten, as Mydei pulled Phainon closer to him so that their bodies were entwined and Mydei's hands tangled in Phainon's hair.

When finally they needed to come up for air, Mydei's face was flushed, the reddest Phainon had ever seen it. He rested his forehead on Mydei's, refusing to stop looking at Mydei for even the smallest blink of his eyes. He must have looked strange, for Mydei let out a small snort and pinched his cheek.

"You're not breathing."

Phainon would go without breathing for the rest of his life if it meant seeing Mydei like this, having Mydei like this. As this thought crossed his mind, however, he realized its futility, and laughed aloud.

"What." Mydei was staring at him, eyes narrowed.

"Nothing," Phainon grinned down at him. He finally felt like he could breathe freely again, after days of struggling to stay above water.

"I just didn't…"

Mydei was still looking at him, listening.

"Yesterday, I—the blessing, it…made me lose control. When *that* happened—" Phainon rushed to finish his thought before Mydei could jump to conclusions. "it was not the way I would have approached it."

"...Approached it?"

Phainon struggled to put his thoughts into words. "Approached…you. In that way. I am not a man inclined to the art of seduction, if you haven't noticed."

Mydei's eyebrow rose a hair.

"I hadn't noticed."

"In any case, I would have… Courted you first," Phainon mumbled, slightly embarrassed.

Mydei was silent for a moment.

"I was. In control."

Phainon stared at him.

"What?"

“The blessing. I’d felt it before. The first time, it made me lose control on the battlefield. I had to be held back by my father’s men before I tore out my companions’ throats.”

Mydei’s throat bobbed.

“I’ve been blessed by Strife before, and each time it became easier to manage the effects and regain control. So—”

“So yesterday, you…” Phainon’s voice came out as practically a whisper.

Mydei’s eyes were steadfast as he looked straight at Phainon.

“Yesterday was not because I lost myself to Strife.”

Phainon’s chest surged with emotion. Mydei had held Phainon *willingly*, had kissed him and lain with him of his own free will.

“I thought that you had somehow figured out what I thought of you, and felt the same, so—”

Phainon leaned forward and nipped at Mydei’s jaw, causing the other to suck in a breath. Encouraged, Phainon moved downward, lips finding the hollow between Mydei’s neck and chest.

“*Phainon*,” Mydei gasped.

“Mydeimos,” Phainon whispered as he felt Mydei’s shiver reverberate through his skin. “Mydei, Mydei,” he repeated as he placed open-mouthed kisses upon Mydei’s neck, mind awash with the knowledge that Mydei had *wanted* him, *still* wanted him.

“I do,” Phainon spoke into Mydei’s skin. “I do feel the same, I—”

He broke off sharply as Mydei’s teeth found his ear.

Breaths ragged, Phainon tried to endure.

“I’ve always—”

Mydei didn’t let him finish, cutting him off by covering his mouth with his hand.

“Quiet.”

Phainon listened, and he did not speak any longer, not even when Mydei took him in his hand, not even when Mydei bit Phainon’s lips and kissed him, stroking him until Phainon came with a shout.

He did not speak any longer, not even after he returned the favor and they had cleaned up, not even when he twined his way around Mydei’s body in his bed.

He did not speak any longer, and instead dreamed of a warrior with hair dyed red.

Chapter End Notes

stared at this chapter so long i can't tell if the logic checks out... please let me know if this makes no sense actually

thanks for reading!
- ogg :3

Chapter 15

Chapter Notes

hello and welcome to the last chapter wooooo :3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Nothing changed between Mydei and Phainon in the coming days. At least, not much. They still sparred together every morning, then went through the day separate from each other aside from the mandatory shared hour for lunch.

Nothing had changed, and yet everything had.

Phainon had never…had anyone the way he had Mydei now. He'd had infatuations in his youth, small, fluttery things that made his heart race. But he'd never had the courage to act on his feelings, never felt he had the right to indulge in frivolous courtships. Bit by bit, his feelings would eventually drip away, like a leak that had never been fixed.

But this time was different.

Even though Phainon had only recently confronted the depth of his feelings towards Mydei, he still naturally expected them to fade away over time. After all, none of his previous feelings lasted longer than a few short weeks, so why would this time be any different?

Phainon was waiting for the moment when his affection for Mydei would eventually fade, the moment when his chest wouldn't threaten to strangle his breath at the sight of Mydei's face.

So far, Phainon was still waiting for that moment to come.

In the meantime, however, he felt content.

A warm feeling surrounded Phainon whenever he walked beside Mydeimos. When Mydei began inviting him over for dinner, offering to cook for him—since when was Mydeimos *domestic*—Phainon felt a funny tingling in his chest.

Whenever Mydei would look at him a little too long, or when Phainon felt the urge to brush the other's hair from his face, whenever Mydei would *let* Phainon touch him like that…

Phainon's chest—no, his heart—felt full.

At every moment of the day, Phainon could barely restrain himself from touching Mydeimos, from pushing him against the closest wall and kissing him. There was not a moment he did not long to clasp Mydei's face between his hands, to link his fingers with Phainon's own.

Phainon ached, and yet he restrained himself.

When Phainon's control slipped, when his resolve would inevitably crack, Mydei would welcome it, pulling Phainon closer to him, fingers digging into Phainon's skin as if he was just as desperate as Phainon. That was impossible—there was no way Mydeimos would want him as deeply as Phainon wanted him—but in moments like this, Phainon couldn't help but wonder *what if*, *what if*.

What if…Mydeimos truly…?

Some nights, Mydei would arrive at Phainon's apartments with a low knock on his door. Phainon would cook—"making salads does not count as *cooking*, Deliverer," came Mydeimos' inevitable, exasperated critique—and make honeyed tea.

When they lay beside each other, everything Phainon tried to repress came out in the form of little touches—brushes to Mydeimos' face, caresses to the crimson tips of his hair, a finger linked around the other's pinky, like a promise made by a child.

Mydei was not as liberal as Phainon in his touches, but they still made Phainon feel…safe. Warm.

When Mydei pulled him closer at night, or even when he would simply brush his knuckles against his in the light of day, Phainon felt unbelievably, irrevocably happy.

Phainon had not known what it felt like to be truly happy for a while, but now he felt like he was drowning in the feeling. If it was possible for him to die of happiness, he was surely on that path, because there was no way this warmth, this *peace*, was sustainable.

Nothing lasted forever, every good thing Phainon had ever come across had eventually faded away, so this surely would do the same. The more time that passed, however, the less Phainon was sure of this fact.

Unsurprisingly, the change in Phainon's demeanor was immediately noticed by Castorice.

"Something's different," she noted over dinner in the market one day.

Phainon frowned. "Different how?"

"You seem…lighter."

Phainon did not know what to say to this. He certainly felt lighter, but there was nothing he could particularly point to as the source of the change. Except—

"Did you finally confess?"

Phainon sputtered, almost choking on air until he finally caught his breath, squawking, "You—I—*what*?"

Castorice hummed into her drink, amused. "To Mydeimos."

Phainon was taken aback. Castorice was not the first to pick up on the change between the two of them. The day before, Aglaea had needed only to glance at him and Mydeimos entering her office together before she let out a small "hmm", a hint of warmth twinkling in her eyes. After the meeting, she pulled them aside and advised them to be discreet in public so as not to give the Council ammunition against the Chrysos Heirs for being *poor role models*.

Not that they would do anything like that, and Phainon knew Aglaea was only doing her duty, but his face felt like it was flushed red for the rest of the day, long after Aglaea's words had left his ears.

He should have expected Aglaea to know right away of their entanglement, being the goddess of Romance, but clearly that was not the only reason, as Castorice had also picked up on the shift. Phainon huffed a little sigh.

"How did you even know?"

She scoffed. "It's not like you were subtle, Phainon. You've done nothing but fawn over him since he arrived in Okhema."

Had he? Phainon knew he had been eager for Mydei's friendship in the beginning, but he had never *fawned* over him. His displeasure with Castorice's assessment must have shown on his face, for she giggled and set her cup down on the table.

"Dearest Phainon, didn't you know you've been obsessed with Mydeimos for ages now?"

Phainon flushed. *Obsessed?* He would never act in such an undignified manner.

"No, I—just wanted to be his friend…" Phainon started to protest, but then trailed off, his mind wandering.

Had he truly only wanted to be Mydeimos' friend back then?

He shook that thought off. "In any case," he declared, "I…uh, did. Confess," he said, the last few words spoken in a mumble to Castorice's growing amusement.

"Ha!" she cried, eyes bright in triumph.

She was uncharacteristically eager to hear the details of their courtship, most of which Phainon refused to divulge. There was nothing wrong with him and Mydeimos being together, but he selfishly wanted to keep all the precious moments that belonged only to them to himself. Castorice kept prodding, however, no matter how tightly Phainon sealed his lips. Unfortunately, he suspected this would not be the last interrogation he would be subjected to from her.

Time kept passing like this, and Phainon was happy.

By the time Phainon's birthday arrived in the third month, spring had slowly ambled into Okhema, the peach blossoms blooming into delicate shades of pink. Spring had come, and Phainon's feelings had not diminished in the slightest. If anything, they had gotten stronger.

Phainon had never known his heart could beat as fast as it did when he gazed upon Mydei's sleeping face, or how it trembled when Mydei kissed his lips, his jaw, his fingertips. The depths of his affection felt bottomless, and he felt dazed by it, by Mydeimos' constant, reassuring presence.

There was so much he struggled to say, but he tried. Phainon kissed his devotion into Mydei's lips, carved his need for Mydei into his skin as he entered him. Since his own arrival in this holy city, Phainon had long cultivated a celebrated career as an orator, but before Mydei he could not speak a single honeyed word. He had not the words to speak his feelings to the other, and could only show him through action.

Until he drew his last breath, Phainon would endeavor to show Mydei just how much he needed his presence. It was strange, Phainon thought, how every moment he spent without Mydei felt heavier than the last. Whenever they reunited after the day apart, Phainon felt like he was floating, anchored to the earth only by the sound of Mydei's voice and the warmth of his skin.

On the morning of Phainon's birthday, Phainon woke up in Mydei's bed to the smell of honeycakes. He followed the smell into the kitchen, where Mydei stood preparing breakfast.

When they had finished cooking and had sat down at the table together, Phainon took his first bite. They tasted sweeter than normal, and Phainon felt warm under Mydei's gaze and the heat of the sun shining through the window. He couldn't place the difference in taste for a moment, and then it hit him.

Ah, he thought. *So this is what love feels like*.

Chapter End Notes

thank you all for your comments, kudos and support as we arrive at the end of this fic... i had to let this chapter ruminate for a bit as i figured out how i wanted to end it. i hope you all have enjoyed the ride! as i've said before, this was my first longfic so i wasn't sure how it was gonna go, but i feel really happy with how this fic has turned out. i didn't have an extended outline for this fic (besides general ideas for plot development and relationship progression) so please forgive me if the pacing is a little off...hehe.

i had such a fun time writing this, and i sincerely hope this chapter brings a satisfying conclusion to this story. i might have some side story ideas but i'm not sure yet whether i want to add them as a related fic to this one or keep them separate, so they might take a while for me to post. i will continue to add minor edits to this fic, since i continue to find mistakes, so be on the lookout for that. in any case, thank you all for being here, and i hope you enjoyed!

as always, thanks for reading!
- ogg :3

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!